

UPPSALA UNIVERSITY



MASTER'S THESIS

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses what I believe to be systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

1.2 Motivation

I approach this research as a complete community member with 15 years of experience in competitive debate across multiple roles: debater, judge, coach, and organizer. This insider perspective informs my reformist motivation to improve formats that have both shaped and limited the community I value. I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential, yet the design of major formats retains decades-old flaws, with game design theories and practices entirely absent from attempts to improve them.

1.3 Problem Statement

Although a very diverse range of debate formats are played all over the world, the practice seen in other games of iterative improvement of the game based on discoveries in game design is entirely absent, most formats being deeply calcified. Their competitive communities evolve new "metas", modes of play and interpretations of rules, without game design supervision. These are poised to lead, in time, to a pattern of accepting instead of solving the issues in the design of these formats. For example, based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I believe and hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they seem to push debaters towards value convergence, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they appear to teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, in my opinion they push communities towards competitive hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research and this thesis does not intend to extensively prove them, although a later section will present their echoes in literature.

1.4 Research Question

How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that manages to elevate its transformative potential (improved

critical thinking, improved discourse, self empowerment etc) by addressing the issues of value convergence, discourse speed and community hierarchy?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it attempts to demonstrate, through behavioral observations and participant-reported experiences collected across five evaluation fields (engagement and appeal, productive pressure, growth direction, community dynamics, and epistemic humility), that a debate format grounded in transformative game design theory can produce clues of meaningful change without sacrificing the intellectual challenge or communal value of the activity.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. Its main contribution to knowledge is the simple proof that debate formats can be designed better if looked at as roleplaying games.

2 BACKGROUND AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Topic Overview

2.2 Debate as Transformative Game

Academic debate formats are games. Following **salen2004rules**<empty citation>, a game is a system in which players engage in artificial conflict, defined by rules, resulting in a quantifiable outcome. Academic debate satisfies all criteria: rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred Snider's 1982 doctoral dissertation at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publication (**snider1984gaming**), established the scholarly foundation for viewing debate as a game while documenting its educational benefits.

But what makes a game *transformative*? **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation> conceptualize transformative role-playing games as those intentionally designed to encourage personal and social change arising from play. For complete transformation to occur, this change must expand beyond the bounds of the original experience and integrate into the participant's daily frames of reality and identity. **daniau2016transformative**<empty citation> conceptualizes this transfer as one "from play skills to human skills," showing through action-research how participants in transformative role-playing games engage across four levels of reality (character, player, person, and human being) and, through structured debriefing, convert in-game abilities into lasting personal competencies. By this standard, a game is truly transformative not merely when participants report enjoyment or in-game learning, but when the experience produces lasting changes in cognition, behavior, or self-concept. The question for academic debate, then, is whether it meets this threshold.

Forensics pedagogy documents debate’s transformative potential across several domains that satisfy this criterion. The most extensively studied is critical thinking: debaters develop the ability to recognize stated and unstated assumptions, evaluate causal inferences, and assess the validity of arguments (**colbert1995enhancing**; **hill1993value**). Beyond cognitive gains, debate serves as a vehicle for empowerment, particularly for previously “silenced student populations” who develop their own voice through the activity (**snider2003gamemaster**), with Urban Debate Leagues leveraging this potential in academically challenged environments. The activity cultivates what **hicks1998public**<empty citation> calls a “democratic ethos”: the capacity to justify convictions in public, respect minority views, and evaluate opposing arguments critically. Oral communication proficiency develops through audience adaptation, where students learn to analyze listeners’ beliefs and norms to frame compelling narratives (**cirlin1997sociological**), while parliamentary formats foster extemporaneous thinking and speaking (**whitmore1998british**). Debate also functions as a “laboratory” for intensive research and information management (**brodabahn2002perspectives**), with the intensity of high-level preparation frequently compared to master’s thesis work (**combs2002applying**). Finally, debate provides a socialization mechanism, integrating students into a sub-culture with specialized language that enhances their sense of belonging to an intellectual community (**cirlin1997sociological**; **kargacin1998state**). Crucially, these effects are not confined to the debate round itself. They transfer into participants’ academic performance, professional communication, and civic engagement, satisfying the criterion of transformation beyond the game.

Empirical research substantiates these claims. **allen1999meta**<empty citation> conducted a meta-analysis finding a significant positive relationship between forensics participation and critical thinking gains (longitudinal $r = .18$), with forensics demonstrating the largest effect among communication activities studied. At the individual study level, **colbert1987effects**<empty citation> found significant critical thinking gains in debaters relative to non-debaters over a full academic year ($F = 31.77$, $p < .001$).

Beyond critical thinking, debate participation correlates with substantial academic outcomes. **mezuk2009urban**<empty citation> found Chicago Debate League participants were 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out than comparable non-participants, with gains concentrated among the lowest-performing students at baseline.

Forensics scholars have proposed several theoretical frameworks to explain how debate produces these transformative effects, each grounded in established learning theory. At the cognitive level, **colbert1995enhancing**<empty citation> argues that critical thinking develops through what he calls “intellectual disequilibrium,” a concept rooted in Piaget’s constructivism, where confrontation with opposing positions forces learners to restructure their mental models rather than simply absorb new information. Debate’s adversarial structure ensures this confrontation is unavoidable: a debater cannot ignore the opposing case but must engage with it directly, producing the cognitive conflict that drives accommodation. At the communicative level, **cirlin1997sociological**<empty citation> draws on Richard Weaver’s rhetorical theory to show that debate develops persuasive skill through audience adaptation: debaters must continuously analyze their listeners’ beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives, a practice that transfers to communication contexts outside the activity. At the social level, Cirlin provides a sociological account of how participation integrates students into a discourse community with shared analytical vocabulary and norms

of evidence evaluation. This linguistic socialization, which Cirlin describes through Weaver’s concept of “sermonic” language, reshapes how participants perceive and engage with arguments in ordinary life. At the civic level, **hicks1998public**<empty citation> argues, drawing on Rawls’s ideal of public reason, that debate cultivates a “democratic ethos”: the disposition to justify convictions through publicly accessible reasoning, to respect minority views, and to evaluate opposing arguments on their merits. Drawing these threads together, **bellon2000research**<empty citation> synthesized evidence from competitive forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology, including research on active learning and the social construction of knowledge, to argue that debate is a uniquely effective pedagogical tool precisely because it engages all of these levels simultaneously. However, these forensics-specific frameworks have not been connected to broader theories of experiential and transformative learning. In the Theoretical Framework section of this paper, I apply **vygotsky1978mind**<empty citation>’s zone of proximal development to the scaffolded learning that occurs through debate coaching and graduated competition, map **kolb1984experiential**<empty citation>’s experiential learning cycle onto the iterative process of debating, receiving feedback, and refining strategy, and draw on research into structured debriefing in simulation and role-playing (**crookall2014engaging**; **daniau2016transformative**) to illuminate how debate’s built-in oral critique enables the reflective processing essential to lasting transformation.

Although forensics pedagogy has successfully documented debate’s transformative effects and proposed explanatory mechanisms, I have yet to find any paper that analyzes major debate formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though **bowman2014educational**<empty citation> acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama, classroom debates and simulation as role-playing games. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated conceptual tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, yet these have not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap in literature, applying game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.3 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, the one I will most focus on in this paper, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., “This House Would legalize the possession of drugs”). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

Understanding debate’s relationship to role-playing games requires first establishing what role-playing games are and where debate fits among related practices. As **zagal2024definitions**<empty citation> observe, defining role-playing games is notoriously contentious, with scholars, designers, and practitioners disagreeing across forms, styles, and communities. However, certain characteristics commonly recur: role-playing games are play activities revolving around the

rule-structured creation and enactment of characters in a fictional world, where players define and pursue their own goals with considerable choice in what actions they can attempt (**zagal2024definitions**). **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation> offer a functional definition: analog role-playing games are “co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness” (p. 16).

Transformative game design literature explicitly positions debate among “cousin forms” of analog role-playing games (**bowman2014educational**; **bowman2025transformative**), alongside simulations, educational role-playing, improv theatre, and psychodrama. The distinction rests not on the act of role-playing itself, which is much the same regardless of community, but on practices, norms, and innovations developing within each community. For the analytical purpose of usefully employing the body of theory developed to explain how and how better can role-playing games harness positive transformative energies, this is already enough to justify the following section. As will be later revealed, most of the theory developed within the Nordic larp tradition explains processes common to all role-playing activities. Going even further however, competitive debate occupies an unusual position among these cousin forms, one that warrants closer examination. While debate is indeed used in educational contexts, it differs fundamentally from close cousins such as work simulations or classroom exercises in ways that bring it closer to analog role-playing games proper. Three theoretical dimensions illuminate this proximity: the depth of character immersion, the strength of alibi, and the leisure-community dimension.

First, regarding immersion: As opposed to work simulations or boardgames, debate requires players to genuinely inhabit an epistemic stance, constructing and defending arguments as if they believed them. This process of active perspective-taking requires what **bowman2010functions**<empty citation> describes as adopting a theory of mind, thinking “as if” one were someone else in a unique set of circumstances (p. 57). The debater must anticipate objections, identify weaknesses, and respond to challenges as someone who holds the assigned position, a cognitive demand that approaches the immersion into character central to role-playing games. As **seo2022good**<empty citation> observes, “the moment one received a motion, one adopted the mindset of a person who was completely convinced of that point of view. One clung to this feeling of absolute conviction to make arguments, sink objections, and display passion” (p. 222). Rules also encourage speaking passionately: **snider1999code**<empty citation> instructs debaters to speak “with energy, enthusiasm, commitment, and variety” and to “act like you care about the arguments” (p. 65). I myself felt, and many colleague debaters also expressed, how the extreme cognitive load that performance in debate demands is incompatible with not fully assuming for the duration of the debate the opinion demanded by the motion, only to then discard it easily in time for the next debate (especially in a competition). Seo corroborates this from the inside: “Midspeech, a speaker rarely experiences the physical strain of thinking so damn hard. The adrenaline induced a mental foggiess that numbed the hard edges of experience” (p. 159). This passionate delivery, especially in the context of such extreme cognitive load, is difficult to sustain through meta-cognitive simulation alone. Affective role-assumption becomes the efficient path, organically eliciting rather than faking the emotions expressed.

bowman2010functions<empty citation> identifies nine types of relationships between players and characters, including the “Fragmented Self,” where a facet of the player’s

personality or interests becomes magnified into a central character trait. Debate characters fit this framework: they represent fragmented selves whose defining feature is epistemic commitment to a particular position. The debater role-plays as someone who believes the motion should pass or fail, adopting that argumentative perspective as the character’s core identity. They find in themselves beliefs they can hold that support the position and banish from thought all other, focusing on a fragment of their identity.

Second, regarding alibi: this concept describes how game participants can act with lessened social consequences, encouraging risk-taking and willingness to fail (**deterding2017alibis**). Debate provides robust alibi through its competitive frame. Because debate is “just a game,” debaters can advance positions they might not advocate publicly and explore uncomfortable arguments. **seo2022good**<empty citation> captures this vividly: the random assignment of sides provided a paradoxical “sense of freedom,” allowing him to “flirt with ideas, unencumbered by expectations of consistency or deep conviction” (p. 20). Work simulations do not offer that. This enables the identity experimentation that **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation> identify as central to transformational containers. It is important to accept that debate however, as all competitive games, does require debaters to perform at and judges them by their peak intellectual ability, not offering them alibi to fail. I would argue however that many TTRPGs and boffer LARPs are designed requiring players to perform intellectually, and that roleplayers within certain communities feel pressure to display acting ability and ability to deeply emotionally immerse. In mainstream North American boffer LARPs, for instance, players who “break game” risk derision or ostracism (**brown2016culture**), while in Nordic larp communities, immersion into character is often treated as an indicator of success, with its absence experienced as personal failure (**harder2018larp**; **pohjola2015steering**). They all however offer players alibi to hold a different identity. Alibi to fail is not essential to a roleplaying game, but alibi to assume the mantle of a character is. On that metric, debate offers players a very strong alibi to embody a character with deeply different opinions from their own: what Seo describes as tracing “the steps of how a sensible person (us!) could arrive at conclusions that might otherwise have seemed alien” (p. 224).

Third, regarding the leisure-community dimension: competitive debate possesses passionate discourse communities distinguishing role-playing games from cousin forms. The World Schools and British Parliamentary circuits encompass hundreds of competitions. Debaters participate voluntarily, often for decades; they develop specialized terminology, shared references, and community norms; they attend tournaments analogous to gaming conventions. The activity is often pursued for its intrinsic satisfactions, not merely as preparation for external goal. This leisure dimension, combined with the vibrant discourse community, positions competitive debate closer to role-playing games than to the educational simulations with which it shares surface similarities.

Furthermore, evidence for debate’s role-playing dimension appears throughout its practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ explicit role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to “become” stakeholders affected by policies. Furthermore, debate ethos as I witnessed it is summoned through traditions that explicitly stage parliamentary fiction: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format performs a fiction of parliamentary deliberation, with debaters and judges alike participating in theatrical conventions inherited from eighteenth-century British debate culture.

Genuine differences between debate and games that are more traditionally seen as analogue role-playing games, such as Dungeons and Dragons, are undeniable: debate lacks the narrative worldbuilding, the character backstories, and the extended campaign structures of tabletop or live-action role-playing. But it is important to recognize that debate’s role-playing operates through the same psychological mechanisms and this justifies applying the substantial body of transformative game design scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects and, more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects.

2.4 Literature Review of Format Critiques

The usefulness of applying transformative game design theory to attempt solving the problems of current debate formats comes also from the apparent failure of current scholarly works in the same endeavor. The largest body of work that analyzes debate as an educational tool is that of forensics pedagogy. This centers around the more predominant formats played in the US (especially American Policy). I will thus focus on reviewing what literature was written that echoes the problems I set out to solve and that forms arguments that are also applicable to the formats that I seek to improve (especially the World Schools format).

2.4.1 The Technical-Public Sphere Tension

A fundamental critique pervading the literature concerns the evolution of debate formats away from public sphere accessibility toward technical sphere insularity. **combs2002psychosocial** documents how both NDT (National Debate Tournament) and CEDA (Cross Examination Debate Association) have evolved into technical sphere activities characterized by: expert-level topic knowledge, speaking rates exceeding what most listeners can process, sophisticated analytical models inaccessible to non-specialists, heavy reliance on extensive note-taking, and specially trained judges.

2.4.2 Value Convergence and Ideological Homogenization

The “closed system” dynamic described by Harris and Smith, cited in **combs2002psychosocial** creates conditions conducive to value convergence. In academic debate, tournament practices are insulated from external feedback and where judges who deviate from community norms are “effectively excluded from the system much like the human system rejects certain bacteria” (**combs2002psychosocial**). This dynamic may cultivate shared assumptions that, while facilitating intra-community communication, potentially diminish debaters’ capacity to engage persuasively with those holding different values.

Crenshaw’s work on feminism in debate, cited by **mcgee2002emancipatory**, illustrates how “argument borrowing” can lead to reductionist treatment of complex intellectual traditions. Debaters observe which arguments succeed in out-rounds, then adopt those lines of reasoning for their strategic value rather than out of genuine engagement with the underlying ideas, producing superficial understanding and reduced capacity for authentic cross-ideological dialogue.

2.4.3 Delivery Practices and Communicative Capacity

Colbert, cited in **combs2002psychosocial**<empty citation>, found that average CEDA debaters spoke at approximately 237 words per minute, while NDT finalists averaged 284 words per minute, with some exceeding 300 words per minute, rates that “greatly exceed what is considered optimal for normal speaking” (**combs2002psychosocial**).

While World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage talking fast through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist. In my observation, this occurs because these formats evaluate on two officially co-equal axes—Style (or Manner) and Content (or Matter)—yet increasing information density improves argumentative quality (more points addressed, more rebuttal, more nuance) while simultaneously reducing intelligibility and persuasive clarity. Because debate operates in an academic setting where the analysis of argumentative quality is perceived as more objective and measurable than the assessment of style, the competitive meta gradually shifts toward privileging Content over Style, even though the evaluation rubric formally treats them as equally important. The result is that the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges. The difficulty to solve this is also captured in literature. (**hicks2002public**) treats the difficulty of defining for what type of audience should debaters make themselves persuasive, comparing **weiss2002audience**<empty citation>’s “audience standard” (being understandable to a regular audience) to his “ideal of public reason” (being understandable to the perfect rational listener), presenting how some educational value is lost either way.

2.4.4 Hierarchical Dynamics and Psychological Safety

In this issue I have observed forensics pedagogy literature is thinnest, yet several authors recognize the risk. **snider1999code**<empty citation> addresses safety and ethics in his Code of the Debate, and in his later practical guide warns organizers to “avoid a counterproductive rigid and hierarchical organization,” noting “I’ve seen groups die when they let ego and status get in the way” (**snider2014sparking**). The International Debate Education Association’s ethics guide for coaches and youth workers similarly acknowledges the “unbalanced power dynamic” inherent in coach-student relationships, compounded by the fact that “older debaters often mentor younger teams” and thus occupy dual roles of peer and authority figure (**idea2024ethics**). Riley and Hollihan further suggest that approximately three years of debate experience are required to compete effectively on the national circuit, effectively excluding students without extensive preparation and reinforcing experience-based hierarchies (**combs2002psychosocial**).

The mechanism behind these dynamics is illuminated by recent research. **prussikora2025cracovian**<empty citation> citing Simon et al. (2020), note that “people placed in competitive intellectual situations tend to develop an adversarial mindset” characterized by myside bias and otherside bias, distorting cognitive appraisal of the issues being debated. They identify competitive debate’s “most crucial weakness”: its rules “do not allow for saying to the opponent: ‘You are right, I was wrong’” instead training debaters to listen for omissions and inaccuracies rather than for understanding (**prussikora2025cracovian**). When win-loss records become the primary measure of status within these hermetic communities, the adversarial structure produces natural hierarchies in which winning debaters gain social authority while losing debaters are

marginalized, reinforcing competitive pressure at the expense of collaborative learning.

2.5 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap. Forensics pedagogy has established debate’s educational benefits and identified tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, but has not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap is the central contribution of this thesis.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated framework synthesizing transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric to explain debate’s transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

3.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

3.1.1 The Transformational Container

The concept of the transformational container originates in the psychoanalytic work of **winnicott1960theory**<empty citation> and was adapted to role-playing game theory by **bowman2021magic**<empty citation>. It describes a bounded space in which consent is emphasized, boundaries are established, and content is calibrated to maintain psychological safety, enabling participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being (**bowman2021magic**; **baird2022transformative**; **bowman2025transformative**). The transformational container builds upon but extends **huizinga1958homo**<empty citation>’s concept of the “magic circle”: whereas all games can be said to possess a magic circle demarcating play from ordinary life, a transformational container additionally requires explicit goals, safety structures, and community support oriented toward lasting personal change (**bowman2025transformative**). I argue that debate, in its existing forms, already constitutes a partially-realized transformational container. The format’s explicit rules and conventions (speaking times, turn order, permissible modes of engagement) establish boundaries that demarcate the debate encounter from ordinary social interaction, much as ritual framing guides participants into a liminal space (**bowman2025transformative**). Within these boundaries, the competitive frame provides what **deterding2017alibis**<empty citation> terms *alibi*: because side allocation is typically random and the activity is understood as a game, the reason a debater advances a given position is “I was assigned this side,” not “I personally believe this.” This deflection of inference from displayed behavior to the game’s structure reduces social risk, granting participants permission to explore unfamiliar arguments, adopt perspectives they might not publicly endorse, and fail without lasting reputational consequences. The judge, meanwhile, functions as the containing authority analogous to the facilitator in transformative game design (**bowman2025transformative**):

a figure who maintains the rules, calibrates the encounter through feedback, and structures the post-round evaluation that helps participants process the experience. However, as **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation> caution, a container’s effectiveness is not guaranteed by its mere existence; communities that fail to support participants may interrupt transformative processes. If competitive pressures become so intense that tournament success conflates with personal worth, the alibi weakens as participants can no longer treat debate as “just a game” and the container’s transformational potential erodes.

3.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following **hugaas2024bleed**<empty citation>, bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position). This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects. **leonard2018bleed**<empty citation>, drawing on **lankoski2012embodied**<empty citation>’s grounded cognition framework, provide neuroscientific grounding for bleed: embodied cognition means that inhabiting a role activates neuropsychological processes that do not fully distinguish fictional from real experience, with hormonal responses associated with trust and social bonding operating in character-mediated interactions just as they do in ordinary life. Moreover, compartmentalizing in-character reactions requires self-regulatory control, a limited resource that depletes during sustained effortful performance. Applied to debate, this framework suggests that extended rounds of inhabiting an assigned position gradually erode the cognitive separation between debater and debater-character, helping explain why sustained debate practice can produce lasting attitudinal shifts.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters should develop what I call epistemic humility: an attitude of skepticism towards one’s own opinions, being open to understand the beliefs of others and to accept them as valid. First of all through the very direct memetic bleed of the opinions of the role played in a debate towards the debater, arguments which can be summoned again outside of the debate. But more than that, after years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right. This mechanism provides a theoretical account of what forensics scholars have documented empirically: Colbert’s “intellectual disequilibrium” (**colbert1995enhancing**), the cognitive conflict produced by engaging with opposing positions, describes the trigger that opens the channel for memetic bleed, while the “democratic ethos” that **hicks1998public**<empty citation> identifies as debate’s civic outcome is the intended result of that bleed integrating into the debater’s empowered attitude.

This bleed of a certain humble attitude connects to **bogost2007persuasive**<empty citation> concept of procedural rhetoric. Bogost argues that every game, though its systems and rules, reflects a certain world-view, that players in time may be persuaded of. The rules of debate inherently postulate that anyone can support anything and that through dialectic processes of presenting arguments for and against, not truth is reached, but a showcase of who is more capable in argument (as two opposite decisions could be taken in two different rounds on the same motion). Thus experienced debaters ideally learn to acknowledge how there may

be much truth in the points made also by the less skilled in argument.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters' ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking. **cirlin1997sociological**<empty citation>'s account of how debaters develop persuasive skill through audience adaptation (outlined above as learning to analyze listeners' beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives) describes precisely this form of procedural bleed and its transfer beyond the activity.

Emancipatory bleed (**kemper2017battle**; **kemper2020wyrding**) explains debate's particular power for students from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container (**bowman2021magic**) to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability. **snider2003gamemaster**<empty citation>'s documentation of debate empowering previously "silenced student populations" through Urban Debate Leagues provides empirical evidence for this form of bleed in competitive debate contexts.

3.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

vygotsky1978mind<empty citation> zone of proximal development explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding: power-pairing ensures challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs, while judges provide guided instruction through post-debate feedback. The debate cycle naturally embodies **kolb1984experiential**<empty citation> experiential learning model, with the debrief, which **crookall2014engaging**<empty citation> and **daniau2016transformative**<empty citation> identify as essential to transformation, built into debate through the oral critique. This scaffolding explains why the "intellectual disequilibrium" that **colbert1995enhancing**<empty citation> identifies as debate's cognitive engine produces growth rather than frustration: coaching, graduated competition, and structured feedback keep the cognitive challenge within the zone where productive accommodation occurs.

3.2 Reframing Forensics Pedagogy Critiques through Transformative Game Design

The critiques identified within forensics pedagogy, echoing the issues identified during the problem statement, can be productively reframed through the theoretical mechanisms of transformative game design, illuminating not only why these problems occur but also suggesting design-based interventions.

3.2.1 Value Convergence as Corrupted Memetic Bleed

What I coined as value convergence can be seen as a failure in memetic bleed. The intended transformative outcome of debate is epistemic humility. However, memetic bleed is mediated by judges, creating vulnerability to what I term *evaluative bleed-in*. Judges role-play as

neutral arbiters, but this role is cognitively demanding and vaguely specified. When judges share common backgrounds, their collective bleed-in produces systematic biases.

Following **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation>, the container’s effectiveness requires psychological safety for all participants, including judges. When judges face social consequences for heterodox opinions that deviate from “emancipatory rhetoric” community consensus, the alibi protecting experimental judgment erodes. What bleeds into debaters is the community’s strategic equilibrium rather than appreciation for intellectual diversity. Debaters, optimizing for competitive success, do “argument borrowing”, adapting strategically: arguments that succeed in elimination rounds or from high-status debaters become templates, and approaches aligned with perceived judicial values propagate.

Design interventions might therefore diversify audiences debaters must persuade, strengthen judge alibi through structural features, and explicitly distinguish in debriefing between “what won this debate” and “what constitutes good reasoning.”

3.2.2 Information Density and Misaligned Procedural Bleed

The critique of information-dense speaking represents misalignment in procedural bleed. When formats reward rapid delivery optimized for expert judges, debaters develop procedural habits adapted to highly specific audiences. The skills that bleed out are real but narrowly optimized, representing failure of transfer.

Design interventions might include evaluation criteria rewarding accessibility alongside substance, or judging paradigms simulating general audiences. By constructing vivid characters for judges to role-play, the bleed-in from character to judge can itself become memetic, the judge taking on the character’s understanding while maintaining expert-level rule comprehension.

3.2.3 Competitive Pressure and the Compromised Container

When competitive pressures become overwhelming, when tournament success determines status and self-worth, the alibi enabling transformation erodes. Participants can no longer treat debate as “just a game” because stakes have become too real. **bowman2013social**<empty citation> documents social conflict within role-playing communities arising from power differentials between facilitators and players, competitive play dynamics, creative agenda disputes, and unprocessed bleed. These patterns parallel competitive debate: power differentials map onto hierarchies between experienced and novice debaters, competitive play produces status systems based on tournament success, and creative agenda disputes manifest as exclusion of those whose approach does not conform to community norms.

This compromise cascades through other mechanisms. Emancipatory bleed requires a container where being taken seriously is possible; rigid hierarchies block this for those positioned as subordinate. The zone of proximal development requires calibrated challenges; competitive anxiety may prevent productive struggle or reflective observation.

Design interventions might distribute status more broadly, emphasize growth over victory, strengthen alibi by making explicit the distinction between game performance and personal worth, and incorporate safety practices adapted from larp design (**bowman2025transformative**).

4 METHODS

4.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making and iterating upon designed artifacts ([coulton2017games](#); [zimmerman2007research](#)). The design process follows [zimmerman2003play](#) <empty citation> iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

4.2 Development Process

Development unfolds through three cyclical phases. In the generation phase, I explore potential mechanics addressing theoretically-identified problems, using brainstorming sessions, design conversations with debate peers, and analysis of existing formats. In the critical scrutiny phase, I evaluate whether candidate designs congruently address problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations), using the theoretical framework as evaluation criteria. In the validation phase, surviving elements undergo increasingly rigorous testing: informal design conversations with experienced debaters, small pilot playtests identifying mechanical problems, and larger playtest sessions with structured observation and post-session debrief.

These phases spiral until the format demonstrates sufficient coherence, playability, and alignment with transformational goals, or allocated resources run out. The first playtest (one debate) was held in March 2026 at the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest, with senior debaters aged 18–20. A second design iteration was drafted based on its findings. The second playtest was conducted in April 2026 with seven veteran debaters in a familiar informal setting, yielding a third design iteration. Both sessions are documented in Annexes A–G.

4.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design, two playtests were organized. During these sessions the research methods used were participant observation and semi-structured post-session group debriefs, followed by qualitative data analysis.

4.3.1 Participant Observation

Following [baker2006observation](#) <empty citation>, I adopted a participant-as-observer role during both playtest sessions. My researcher status was known to participants, and I participated actively in the second session to obtain firsthand understanding.

Observation focused on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework’s predictions.

Informed by the advice of **spradley1980participant<empty citation>**, I recorded field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, captured key moments, quotations, and behavioral observations using structured protocols. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the sessions, elaborated, added contextual observations, and recorded analytical reflections. Both sessions were audio-recorded with participant consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

4.3.2 Participants

Debaters were recruited for the first session with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest and the south of Romania. They directly inquired various clubs about including a playtest as part of their weekly activity and issued open calls for debaters in organizing the session. The second session was organized through personal contacts: participants were veteran debaters known to the researcher, recruited informally rather than via open call.

In Romania, the young adults debate community is largely homogenous in experience; the sample is thus representative of the format’s most likely target audience: experienced, not novice, debaters.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative.

The two sessions involved a total of approximately fifteen participants.

4.3.3 Post-Session Debriefs

Semi-structured group debriefs complemented observation by accessing perspectives not directly observable. The debrief took two forms in each session. First, participants completed individual written debrief forms (Annex C) developed based on the theoretical framework’s predictions about transformative mechanisms. Second, immediately following the written forms, a semi-structured group discussion was held with all participants together: the researcher introduced a set of pre-planned open questions derived from the evaluation fields, but allowed the conversation to develop organically, following participant-introduced threads and encouraging elaboration on emergent themes. This group discussion format—closer to a semi-structured focus group than a structured interview—proved particularly valuable for surfacing inter-participant dialogue and spontaneous comparative reflection that individual forms could not capture.

Debrief discussions occurred immediately following each session, ensuring fresh recall. They were conducted in person and supplemented by the researcher’s reflexive notes recorded within 24 hours.

4.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented comparative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces different experiences than existing formats. This aligns with

experimental game design methodology (**waern2015experimental**), where design experimentation becomes research when “the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design.”

Before data collection, the five evaluation fields derived from the research question and theoretical framework were operationalized into a taxonomy of *potential clues*: specific observable behaviors or reported experiences that would count as evidence for or against the format’s intended effects in each field. Both positive clues (behaviors consistent with the format achieving its intended effect) and negative clues (behaviors indicating a design gap or failure to achieve it) were specified at this stage. This pre-specification ensures the analysis remains responsive to disconfirming evidence rather than converging only on confirming observations. The complete taxonomy, reproduced in Annex I, thus defines in advance what would need to be observed to consider the format effective or ineffective in each field.

Between playtest sessions, rapid analysis focused on actionable insights: what mechanics worked and should be preserved, what did not work and caused confusion or disengagement, and what surprised me and suggested new opportunities. This treats playtesting as “play as research” (**zimmerman2003play**), with each session generating questions informing the next design cycle.

After the second playtest, systematic comparative analysis proceeded through three phases following **lankoski2015formal**<empty citation>: initial coding labeling data segments descriptively; comparative analysis organizing codes around continuity, difference, and novelty (with novel and different behaviors weighted as stronger design evidence than continuities, which may reflect carry-over training); and mapping confirmed clues onto the pre-specified taxonomy, connecting each to the format mechanics that appear to produce them.

This approach can demonstrate: (a) the designed format produces experiences participants describe as different; (b) specific mechanics appear connected to specific differences; and (c) differences align with intended goals. It cannot demonstrate persistence, superiority, or generalizability, appropriate limitations for proof-of-concept Research through Design where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation or usage.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University’s ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants were informed of the purpose and context, how data would be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All were able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input was used in developing this format were informed of context and credited. All data is stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and will be deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data has been anonymized and is not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide will be followed. Debate topics will avoid personal trauma topics and debaters will be able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters

will be able to always talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters will be able to exit without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants will have pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

4.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approach this research as a complete community member (**adler1987membership**). My fifteen years in competitive debate have shaped not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This informs several positions I must acknowledge: insider knowledge enabling nuanced understanding but potentially creating blind spots; reformist motivation emerging from genuine frustration with existing formats, predisposing me toward confirming my critique; a novel disciplinary lens through game design rather than the educational or rhetorical frameworks common in forensics scholarship; and power dynamics created by my status as former Team Romania coach and successful debater, which may influence participant responses. My competitive success within the formats I critique creates additional tension regarding whether my familiarity enables recognition of subtle issues or obscures problems I cannot fully perceive.

To support reflexive awareness, I completed every playtest journal with a reflexive note (**knott2022interviews**), actively seeking data contradicting expectations. The second session introduced a heightened positionality challenge: all participants were close personal acquaintances, which deepened rapport and informal observation access while simultaneously amplifying the risk of social desirability effects and confirmation bias. This proximity is acknowledged as a limitation.

5 DESIGN OF THE INSIDE OUT FORMAT

5.1 From Theory to Design

This chapter corresponds to the generation and critical scrutiny phases of the Research through Design methodology outlined in the Methods chapter. The theoretical framework produced three design predictions constituting the design brief. The Inside Out format is presented in full in Annex A, and annexes B-D present its chronological evolution; the following sections argue why each structural element exists and how it serves the theoretical objectives.

5.2 Design Rationale

Each structural choice in Inside Out traces to the theoretical framework’s diagnosis of how traditional formats produce corrupted bleed, misaligned skill transfer, and container compromise. This section justifies the format’s core design decisions.

5.2.1 Why Multiple Teams Defending Values?

Traditional formats position two teams in binary opposition, a structure whose procedural rhetoric (**bogost2007persuasive**) teaches that every issue has exactly two sides. Inside Out replaces this with three Value Defender teams, each advocating for a different value held by the Subject. This restructuring addresses several identified problems simultaneously.

The multi-team structure produces a procedural rhetoric of complexity and humility: the format asserts through its rules that decisions involve balancing multiple legitimate human values, not choosing between right and wrong. This directly counters the corrupted memetic bleed driving value convergence by positioning value pluralism at the core of the conflict rather than treating it as a side effect of switch-side argumentation. Because values are assigned rather than chosen, the design also strengthens alibi (**deterding2017alibis**) for assuming a fragmented identity (**bowman2010functions**), the debater-character relationship is explicitly about inhabiting a value, making perspective-taking the core mechanic. And because the Subject is a person with specific background, circumstances, and values rather than an abstract decision-maker, the motion reinforces that decisions are products of context, resisting the abstraction that enables generic argument templates and the drift toward what **goodnight1982spheres**<empty citation> identified as the technical sphere of argumentation.

Furthermore, the structure cultivates collaborative alongside combative skills. Value Defenders must persuade the Subject, a sympathetic listener making a genuine decision, not defeat an opponent. This corrects the misaligned procedural bleed by developing communication habits adapted to contexts beyond competitive debate, where persuasion typically involves collaboration rather than combat (**cirlin1997sociological**). The Subject also creates a natural accessibility incentive: if a Value Defender speaks incomprehensibly, their arguments are simply not weighed in the decision, a consequence that naturally incentivises clarity.

5.2.2 Why Split Subject and Evaluator?

In traditional formats, a single judge both determines the winner and provides feedback, entangling evaluation with adjudication. Inside Out separates these functions: the Subject makes decisions within the debate, while the Evaluator observes and offers commendations.

This split means winning the debate is not a goal in itself but a method for growing, symbolized through commendations rather than victories. Decision-making within the debate becomes an act not of arbitrating but of synthesizing toward a position by acknowledging the interplay between values, a form of procedural rhetoric that models how real-world deliberation works, steering corrupted memetic bleed away from value convergence and toward epistemic humility. The Subject learns to synthesize; the Value Defenders learn to persuade collaboratively; and the Evaluator, freed from adjudicating competition, can focus on recognizing communicative virtue, maintaining the transformational container by decoupling status from competitive victory.

5.2.3 Why Commendations Instead of Scores?

Replacing scores and victory with commendations moves the format from a paradigm of competing against others toward one of improving oneself. Two debaters can be excellent in entirely different ways, a message reinforced by the diversity of commendation categories (“Compassionate Discourse” alongside “Strategic Rebuttal”) and the badge progression system that builds unique skill profiles over time. This directly addresses the container compromise identified in the theoretical framework: when status derives from demonstrated growth rather than competitive victory, the zero-sum dynamics that erode the transformational container (**bowman2021magic**; **bowman2025transformative**) are structurally dismantled.

The commendation system also resolves a persistent tension in modern debate formats between content density and persuasive discourse, precisely the misaligned procedural bleed identified in the theoretical framework. Commendations dissolve this conflict: debaters can pursue recognition for persuasive discourse alongside and equally with recognition for academic rigor and complexity, because these are separate categories rather than competing dimensions collapsed onto a single scale.

5.2.4 Why Oral Feedback Instead of Oral Critique?

In traditional formats, the oral critique centers on the judge’s decision: the judge explains who won and why, and advises debaters on what would have changed the result. The implicit question is “how could I have won?” Inside Out reframes post-round interaction as oral feedback, centering on demonstrated skills and developmental trajectory. The Evaluator explains the commendations awarded, articulates why particular moments demonstrated particular skills, and offers advice oriented toward growth. The implicit question shifts to “what am I developing, and how can I develop further?” This connects the debate experience to the debater’s broader growth trajectory rather than to a single round’s competitive outcome, maintaining the transformational container by structuring the debrief around growth rather than victory.

5.3 Synthesis and Design Tensions

Several tensions in this design constitute productive questions for playtesting. Will competitive motivation survive without win-loss outcomes, or will debaters socialized in traditional formats experience commendations as insufficient stakes? The Subject team bears a unique cognitive burden in synthesizing three value streams, and whether this is productive challenge or overwhelming difficulty depends on experience level and motion complexity. The format’s novelty (four teams, new roles, unfamiliar mechanics) may create barriers to entry for newcomers. Without victory as evaluative anchor, commendation judgments may feel more subjective; clear criteria and Evaluator training will likely be essential.

6 RESULTS

The question admits two decomposed sub-questions. First: can a research method of applying transformative game design theory to this problem domain be demonstrated? Second:

does that research method yield expected results? Each is addressed in turn.

6.1 Demonstrating the Method: The Design Process as Contribution

The first sub-question is answered by the thesis itself. The systematic progression from theoretical analysis through iterative design to empirical testing constitutes a worked example of operationalizing transformative game design theory in debate. The reasoning connecting each design iteration to observed player behavior is documented in Annexes A, B, and G; whether or not the resulting format succeeds transformatively, the method has been rendered explicit and repeatable.

6.2 Evaluating the Results: Evidence from Playtests

The second sub-question concerns whether the designed format shows signs of achieving its intended effects. Two playtests were conducted and analyzed using the clue-taxonomy method described in Section 4; the complete taxonomy is in Annex I. The following analysis discusses the most significant confirmed clues across the five evaluation fields. Behavioral and emergent evidence is weighted above self-report throughout, and social desirability effects are treated as a particular concern for Field 1 (see Annex I preamble).

6.2.1 Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

For a debate format to sustain a community, it must be sufficiently engaging to generate voluntary, repeated participation. Several clues point in this direction, though the social desirability caveat above applies with particular force here.

Self-reported engagement was consistently positive across both playtests: participants described the format as “surprisingly liberating,” reported “a lot less anxiety,” and called the Huddle phase “very very fun.” These reports constitute moderate evidence only, given the playtest context. The stronger engagement signal is behavioral: in the second playtest, participants spontaneously adopted the term “inner voices”—a term absent from the ruleset—to refer to each other during play. Organic language generation of this kind suggests genuine imaginative investment rather than performed enthusiasm, and is coded as a strong clue in Annex I.

A recurring negative engagement clue was the scripted Rolling Out ritual, reported as “very robotic” in the first playtest and producing mumbling and requests for justification in the second. Design iteration has continued to address this—the ritual was revised in the third iteration (Annex H), though that version remains untested.

The differential appeal across participant profiles is a relevant secondary finding. Women and debaters who had been less successful in traditional formats expressed consistent preference for Inside Out across both sessions; the one participant who found the format unsatisfying was a highly competitive debater who missed the “ego-boosting” experience of decisive victory. Whether this profile-specific response represents a limitation or a design confirmation depends on the format’s intended audience.

Section 5 noted format novelty as a potential barrier to entry. The 40-minute brief required in both sessions—even with experienced debaters—confirms that the learning curve is real. However, both sessions produced substantively engaged play within a single session, suggesting the cost is one of onboarding rather than fundamental inaccessibility.

6.2.2 Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

Competitive debate’s transformative potential depends partly on pressure: the cognitive and social demands of the activity push participants to grow. A format without sufficient challenge risks becoming a low-stakes social exercise without developmental benefit. Clues from both playtests suggest the format redirects rather than removes intellectual pressure, though this redirection also surfaced a significant design gap.

Participants in both playtests engaged with high effort: in the first session, players constructed elaborate and nuanced solutions, made careful value-priority arguments, and delivered some notably passionate speeches—try-hard investment by any standard; in the second, players spontaneously produced contextually rich, roleplay-oriented speeches with worldbuilding detail, none of which was instructed. Participants in the first playtest described “architecting solutions” as “very complex and interesting strategically,” a self-report consistent with the behavioral evidence. Both sessions also produced strikingly high levels of acting and role-play, raising the question of whether emotional expressiveness came at the cost of analytical rigor; the evidence suggests it did not, as elaborate solutions, practicalities-based reasoning, and careful value hierarchies remained consistently present alongside the emotional engagement.

A notable finding about the source of performance pressure: across both sessions it became clear that the mechanic driving effort was not the win/loss dynamic (which is absent) nor primarily the commendation system, but a social one—participants wanted to be recognized and appreciated by their fellow Inner Voices and by the Subject for the quality and resonance of their contributions. This directly addresses the design tension raised in Section 5 about whether competitive motivation can survive without win-loss outcomes: the answer appears to be yes, but via a different mechanism than the commendation architecture alone—social recognition within the group shifts competitive stakes from zero-sum outcome-seeking toward collaborative reputation.

A notable negative clue was Subject role confusion: in the first playtest the Subject player described not knowing “what to say,” uncertain how to hold emotional investment and evaluative neutrality simultaneously, producing visible hesitation. This was a specific design gap in the S0 and S1 instructions, addressed in the second design iteration; the confusion did not recur in the second playtest. The second session also offered a partial answer to the design tension about whether the Subject’s cognitive burden is productive challenge or overwhelming difficulty: the Subject who navigated the role most successfully was the one who leaned into roleplay rather than maintaining analytical detachment—simply inhabiting the character, responding emotionally, and asking questions from genuine curiosity resolved the cognitive tension of trying to reconcile the roleplay and evaluative functions simultaneously. This is consistent with the broader argument in Section 2 that debate is fundamentally a form of role-playing and cannot be done well without inhabiting the role.

The commendation system remains a partially open question: evaluators found commen-

dations difficult to assign consistently at small informal scale, pointing to a mechanism that is conceptually coherent but calibrationally immature.

6.2.3 Field 3: Growth Direction—Useful Skills and Perspectives

A central design goal was to redirect the skills debate develops toward more transferable outcomes: persuasive communication, perspective-taking, contextual reasoning, and collaborative discourse. The clues here are mixed: strong behavioral evidence in the second playtest, moderate self-report in the first, and one significant negative clue in the first.

In the first playtest, participants articulated learning to “think about the context of decisions,” to be “more human and more honest about human nature,” and to recognize that “sometimes decisions are personal, not universal.” These self-reported reflections are moderate evidence: they align with the format’s procedural rhetoric (**bogost2007persuasive**) and are on-target with design intent, but they are retrospective and unverified by pre-session baseline. A behaviorally notable pattern across both sessions is that play diverged increasingly from standard debate conventions as each session progressed: early in the debate participants applied familiar genre habits, but speech by speech they adjusted toward the format’s distinct demands. Equally important is what was absent: no non-standard or unhelpful new play behaviors were rewarded, and no performative hollow emotionality was observed—negative clues that, had they manifested, would have undermined the growth-direction claim (see Annex I).

The second playtest provides the strongest positive clues for this field. All players immediately adopted a roleplay-oriented stance—second-person address, direct eye contact with the Subject, contextual worldbuilding detail—none of which was instructed in the ruleset. This spontaneous behavior is behavioral rather than self-reported, and coded as a strong clue in Annex I: it suggests the format’s structure elicits perspective-taking without instruction, though this observation is confined to a single session and cannot yet be called reliable.

A further behavioral cluster that emerged in the second playtest is worth noting for this field: players spontaneously adopted a polite and collaborative form of counter-argumentation—shifting focus and building on others’ contributions rather than dismantling them—and the second round of speeches showed organic movement toward a common solution, with players converging rather than intensifying conflict. These patterns are novel relative to standard debate and among the clearest procedural rhetoric effects observed.

6.2.4 Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

One of the design’s primary goals was to reduce the hierarchical and adversarial dynamics that contribute to attrition and harm in competitive debate communities. This field presents both the most consistent positive clues and the most notable pattern of absent negative clues.

Reduced anxiety was reported consistently and independently across both playtest groups—“much much less anxiety-inducing” than standard competitive debate, a “feeling of salvation regardless of result,” the sense that “everyone distinguished himself by his own style.” The multi-session consistency strengthens confidence in this finding beyond what a single playtest would allow. One honest caveat is offered: the format’s reduced established status means

less social capital is staked on performance, so some portion of the anxiety reduction may not persist in a mature Inside Out circuit. This is an empirical question for future study.

A strong behavioral clue from the second playtest is the emergent norm that “outright attacking others’ points feels wrong, disrespectful, and unnecessary.” This was not stated in the ruleset; it arose from the format’s structural logic—a procedural rhetoric outcome in the precise sense theorized by **bogost2007persuasive**<empty citation>. That players found collaborative framing more natural and more effective than adversarial rebuttal suggests a self-reinforcing alignment between competitive incentives and transformative design intent.

Both sessions produced instances of brave, unconventional play that was acknowledged and positively received. In the second playtest, brave play took multiple forms: one player opened their subject speech with a background soundtrack playing from their phone; the C team built their entire case around a worldbuilt character (the Subject’s mother) and her emotional stakes; players throughout the room adopted expressively roleplay-heavy delivery, and the room responded with visible gesture-based approval—laughing, nodding, leaning forward—throughout.

Equally informative is what was not observed. None of the three negative clues for this field—expressions of distress, arrogant or unempathetic behavior, or praise of such behavior—manifested across either playtest or in the transcripts. Given the emotional intensity of some moments in the second session (including an unplanned bleed event where a participant shared privately that the scenario resonated with a real-life situation they were facing that same day), the absence of distress is a meaningful signal that the debrief structure provided sufficient containment.

6.2.5 Field 5: Epistemic Humility

The deepest transformative aim of the format is to cultivate epistemic humility: a disposition to take multiple perspectives seriously, to recognize that different value frameworks can each be valid, and to hold one’s conclusions with appropriate uncertainty. This field contains some of the strongest behavioral clues in the dataset, though all are from a single playtest session.

In the first playtest, one participant explicitly articulated: “every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us.” This moderate clue is notable for being unprompted, and for capturing precisely the attitudinal shift the format targets. Further supporting evidence from the first session includes participants recognizing that arguing someone is “morally wrong” for a personal decision feels “a bit absurd” in this format, and the observation that the format makes personal value priorities legible rather than evaluating them against an external standard.

The strongest clues come from the second playtest. The spontaneous drift toward synthesis in the second round of Inner Voice speeches—players converging rather than intensifying conflict, despite no rule incentivizing this—is a behavioral, transcript-confirmed, emergent indicator that the format’s procedural logic orients participants toward integration rather than dominance. A notable related finding is that players in the second session organically renamed themselves “Inner Voices” during play—a label that positions them as parts of a shared internal deliberation rather than opposing sides, colleagues rather than competitors. This renaming was subsequently formalized in the third design iteration.

The second playtest debrief also generated a theoretically rich conversation about how the S0 speech institutionalises the practice of surfacing personal biases openly. Participants contrasted this with standard formats, in which the pretense of objectivity is maintained throughout: those formats, they argued, falsely presuppose that bias can be excluded, propagating the notion that only one type of “objective” person can judge well and legitimizing social pressure to perform that identity. The S0 mechanism, by contrast, frames bias as perspective rather than contamination—a structural move toward epistemic humility that is enforced by the format before any argument is made.

The unplanned bleed event—a participant sharing privately that the scenario resonated with a real-life situation they were facing that same day—is the single highest-strength clue across the entire dataset: it was spontaneous, private (not performed for the researcher), and constitutes the transformational mechanism functioning exactly as theorized in Section 3.

No negative clues for this field—unequivocal condemnation of positions or belief-holders, or praise of such condemnation—were observed across either playtest or the transcripts. The absence is meaningful given that both motions used involved choices with genuine ethical weight.

6.3 Proof of Concept Assessment

Taken together, the clues documented across both playtests provide reasonable grounds for a proof-of-concept claim. The format:

- was experienced as engaging and appealing, particularly by participants underserved by traditional formats;
- maintained sufficient intellectual pressure through a redirection rather than removal of challenge;
- elicited spontaneous perspective-taking, value exploration, and contextual reasoning;
- generated emergent community norms oriented toward collaborative rather than adversarial discourse; and
- produced instances of epistemic humility, bleed effects, and personal value resonance consistent with the theoretical framework’s predictions.

No single piece of evidence is conclusive. Small sample sizes, the absence of longitudinal follow-up, and the researcher’s dual role as designer and observer all limit what can be inferred. However, the convergence of multiple independent clues across two separate playtest groups provides a coherent picture that justifies continued investigation. The format warrants further empirical study with larger groups, more experienced facilitators, and longitudinal measurement of the skill and attitudinal outcomes theorized here.

6.4 Limitations

The original design of this study envisioned approximately four iterative playtest sessions. Two were completed within the thesis timeline. While this reduces the number of design

iterations and the breadth of participant exposure, both sessions yielded substantive observational and debrief data sufficient for proof-of-concept assessment. Future work should extend the iterative cycle.

The researcher’s insider position as a fifteen-year competitive debater and the format’s designer is both a strength (enabling nuanced interpretation of participant behavior) and a limitation (creating potential for confirmation bias in clue selection and interpretation). Reflexivity notes were maintained throughout, and the Annex I clue list explicitly notes the evidential strength and directionality of each inference.

Finally, both playtest groups consisted of experienced debaters already familiar with competitive formats. The format’s performance with novice participants—for whom the contrast with standard debate would be less salient—remains untested.

7 Discussion

The results chapter established, clue by clue, that Inside Out behaves the way a transformative debate format is supposed to behave. This discussion does something different: it reads the playtests back through the theoretical framework of Section 3 to ask where the theory explains what happened, where the results press on its edges, and where the encounter between the two points toward extensions the framework needs if it is to operate at the level of precision intentional design demands. Several of the most striking findings emerged not because the framework correctly predicted them but in spite of its silence on them; those silences are the productive output of this thesis.

The extensions that follow address seemingly separate surfaces—alibi, judges, players, agencies, peers, evaluators, governance—but they converge on a single claim, and it is worth stating it here so the reader can read each subsection as evidence for it. *In a transformative competitive format, the rulebook is the smallest of the surfaces that shape the participant’s experience.* The real work of design sits in the apparatus that surrounds the rulebook: the roles, stances, agencies, peer economies, evaluative practices, and governance structures that each extension below examines.

7.1 Genre Alibi and the Filter on What Survives in a Format’s Meta

deterding2017alibis<empty citation>’s account of alibi treats it as a social license to participate: “I was assigned this side” deflects inference from the player’s displayed behavior to the game’s structure. The playtests show the concept needs a second axis. The Rolling Out ritual—mechanically identical in intent to any framing device used in transformative LARP—was reported as “very robotic” in the first playtest and drew mumbling in the second, while the term “Inner Voices” was adopted spontaneously by the same participants. Both moves are licensed by the alibi. What distinguished them was whether they matched the genre participants had licensed themselves to be there for. Debate’s social contract treats ceremonial language as frivolous; roleplay-adjacent self-naming, by contrast, reads as imaginative investment and is kept. The alibi grants permission; the genre of the alibi filters which permissions are cashed in.

This has a direct implication for the framework. **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation>’s list of designable surfaces treats the container’s framing and ritual structure as one such surface, but does not distinguish between alibi-as-license and alibi-as-genre-declaration. A framing device appropriate to a LARP weekend can be procedurally correct in a debate format and still fail, because the genre of the format sets a prior over what participants will accept.

7.2 Value Convergence Revisited: The Judge as the Average Unbiased Person

The playtests support but also sharpen the corrupted-memetic-bleed account of value convergence (Section 3). The underlying pathology is not simply that judges happen to be demographically similar; it is that they are all asked to roleplay the *same* archetype—“the average, unbiased person”—and the words “average” and “unbiased” are themselves ideologically loaded. Everyone converging on one role produces drift regardless of the judges’ individual backgrounds, because the role itself pulls interpretation toward a single imagined audience and sanctions deviation. Inside Out’s second-playtest debriefs captured this almost verbatim: participants contrasted the S0 speech, which frames bias as perspective rather than contamination, against “the pretense of objectivity” they located in standard formats, and argued that the standard framing itself propagates the notion that only one kind of “objective” person can judge well.

Four structural choices in Inside Out act on this mechanism simultaneously: the Interlocutor roleplays a specific named character rather than a composite neutral; there are three teams rather than two; persuasion targets values rather than policy; and the S0 speech grants the Subject worldbuilding license, providing an explicit alibi to interpret the same character differently across rounds. Switch-side debating already cultivates humility through its own procedural rhetoric (**bogost2007persuasive**); the design task is to defend that humility against the homogenizing pressure that otherwise leaks back in. The framework extension this suggests is that the judge-role’s psychological specificity is a first-order design variable, not a community-support afterthought. Further research should compare circuits differing in judge-role specification—named-character, demographically-scripted, explicitly partisan—to map how judge-role pluralism shapes the memetic pathways available to debaters.

7.3 Steering: A Missing Construct for the Subject’s Dual Stance

The first playtest’s Subject described not knowing “what to say,” caught between emotional investment and evaluative neutrality; the second playtest’s Subject resolved the tension by leaning into the roleplay rather than maintaining analytical detachment. The framework, as written, has no construct that names what the second Subject did. Bleed describes what flows into the player; alibi describes the social license to let it in; neither captures the player’s capacity to inhabit the character while retaining an external stance to notice what the scene is doing.

The Nordic theory of steering (**montola2015steering**; **pohjola2015steering**) is precisely this missing construct. Steering describes the player’s ongoing negotiation between in-character inhabitation and out-of-character authorship—the capacity to play “as if from

inside” while still shaping the fiction from outside. The transformative game design literature has absorbed bleed almost without qualification but has treated steering as a LARP-practitioner term rather than a theoretical primitive, and the omission becomes costly the moment a format asks a participant to be both a roleplayer and a reflective judge of the roleplay. Importing steering into the framework does two things: it names what the successful Subject did, and it makes the Subject’s evaluative burden a design parameter (how much steering the role requires) rather than an individual skill problem.

7.4 Procedural Rhetoric and Agency: Nguyen Extends Bogost

Several of the strongest results were procedural rhetoric effects in **bogost2007persuasive** sense: the emergent norm against adversarial rebuttal, the collaborative drift toward synthesis in the second round of Inner Voice speeches, and the spontaneous roleplay stance all arose from the format’s structural logic rather than from instruction. **nguyen2020games**’s account of games as the art of agency restates this point at a different altitude, and its addition to the framework is productive. Games shape players not only by the worldviews their rules encode (Bogost) but by the agencies they make available (Nguyen): what kinds of action, what kinds of deliberation, what shape of success the format authorizes the player to pursue. Inside Out authorizes a different agency than traditional debate—collaborative persuasion oriented toward a Subject’s decision rather than zero-sum victory over an opponent—and the emergent norms are what that different authorization looks like in play.

The framework extension is modest but useful: procedural rhetoric describes the argument a format makes; agency-shaping describes the kind of player it cultivates. Transformation sits at the intersection, and both lenses are needed to design for it.

7.5 Social Recognition as the Pressure Mechanism

The framework anticipated that removing win-loss outcomes would require a replacement source of competitive motivation, and the commendation architecture was designed to provide it. The playtests report something the framework did not predict: the mechanic driving high effort was neither the win/loss dynamic nor primarily the commendation system, but a social one—participants wanted to be recognized and appreciated by their fellow Inner Voices and by the Subject for the quality and resonance of their contributions. Pressure was present and productive. Its source was peer regard, not progression.

This is a genuine gap in the existing transformative game design literature, which has extensive theory about the container, alibi, and bleed, but little about what sustains motivational intensity in the container’s absence of external competition. Social recognition within a bounded group is itself a transformational pressure: it aligns with the format’s goals (collaborative persuasion is what gets recognized), it operates at the speed of the session (no need for circuit-scale memory), and it is durable under the removal of win-loss. The framework extension is to name this explicitly as a third category of pressure alongside competitive stakes and progression architecture, and to treat it as a designable surface in its own right.

7.6 Growth Legibility: The Undertheorized Designable Surface

The commendation system succeeded in decoupling status from competition and was received with genuine enthusiasm (“scratching the make-a-build itch”), but evaluators reported difficulty assigning commendations consistently, and one raised the risk of “farming”—stylized play optimized for commendation coverage rather than development. Both difficulties point to the same problem: the framework specifies what transformation *is* (bleed, identity work, memetic uptake) but not how a facilitator *sees* it occurring in real time, and not how a progression architecture can be designed so that optimizing for its rewards equals the development it is meant to measure.

Growth legibility names this missing surface. It has two components. *Observational legibility* requires behavioral specification of what growth looks like—not “epistemic humility” as an aspiration but something a trained evaluator can mark as it happens in a five-minute speech—together with evaluators trained to distinguish genuine transformation from its performance. *Anti-farming legibility* requires that commendation criteria be tight enough that optimizing for them *is* developing the underlying capacity; underspecified criteria produce hollow compliance and actively interfere with transformation by rewarding its simulation. Competitive debate makes the gap impossible to avoid, and in doing so makes it designable. Growth legibility belongs on **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation>’s list of designable surfaces.

7.7 Governance, Not Rules, Carries the Meta

The second playtest debrief produced the most important empirical observation in this thesis, and it is about something the framework does not address at all. Participants reconstructed how the drift toward speedtalking in British Parliamentary, and its later contamination of World Schools after the judge pools merged, was a *governance* story rather than a rules story. As the founding university teachers disengaged from BP, rule interpretation fell to whoever held social power in the circuit, and they systematically privileged the skill hardest to master—logical density—because that was what sustained their standing. A new format dropped into that community inherits the same governance pathology regardless of its ruleset.

Community support, as **bowman2025transformative**<empty citation> frames it, is too thin a category: what matters is the *governance layer*—how rules are interpreted, how evaluators are trained, how motions are authored, how commendations are constructed and displayed across a season, and whose voice sets the meta’s direction of drift. This layer is not designed in this thesis, and it is more consequential for the format’s long-run behavior than anything in the format specification. The framework extension is to recognize governance structure as a designable surface of its own, outside the framing of a single game, sitting above the format rather than alongside it. Comparative research on circuits where formal rules are stable but governance structures differ (pre- and post-merger WS is a natural case) would test whether governance alone predicts meta drift in the way the playtest debrief suggests it does.

7.8 Modularity, and an Honest Note on the Process

The framework tends to treat transformative formats as integrated wholes whose components reinforce one another. Inside Out’s design is also that, but it is additionally decomposable into five components each of which could be transplanted into an existing format without the others: the commendation system; splitting the judge into an in-debate Interlocutor whose performance is itself evaluated and an external Evaluator whose is not; three teams rather than two; a judge who roleplays a specific named character; and teams prescribed values but granted creative freedom over the solutions that express them. The framework extension is a modularity lens: treating transformative designs as candidate sets of transplantable mechanisms rather than monolithic experiences.

Two honest notes complete this discussion. First, the thesis narrates a deductive arc but the design emerged intuitively and was retrofitted to theory; that it held testifies to framework coherence, not design epistemology. Second, the format’s audience is structurally narrow. Only teenagers and students in their early twenties have the time budget sustained deliberative play demands, which is itself the reason playtest recruitment was difficult and which bounds the populations to whom these findings can be expected to generalize.

8 Conclusion

Alfred “Tuna” Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students—one of whom I was privileged to be—continued his work across related fields, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game? This thesis takes one step into that question.

A “how can” research question unfolds in three stages, and it is worth being explicit about which of them this thesis answered. The first stage asks whether the task is approachable at all—whether the conceptual tools required even apply to the object of study. Sections 2 and 3 answer this: debate is a class of transformative role-playing games, and the apparatus of transformative game design can be brought to bear on it without conceptual distortion. The second stage asks whether a concrete attempt at the task can be carried through. Sections 4–5 answer this by documenting the design of the Inside Out format and the iterative process through which it arrived at its current shape. The third stage asks whether the attempt produced anything of value. The results and discussion chapters answer this in their respective registers: clue-by-clue proof that the format behaves as theorized, and theory-facing extensions opened up by the encounter between framework and playtest.

What the thesis does *not* claim is that the Inside Out format, in its current state, solves the problems identified in the problem statement. It takes a first and not strictly necessary step in a much longer process of reform, whose later stages involve refinement, community adoption, governance design, and the slow work of shifting a meta. Making a game is the smaller problem; carrying one into a community with established governance, calcified metas, and invested practitioners is the larger one, and this thesis does not attempt it.

The enduring contribution of this thesis is best stated as a single claim, of which the work's more specific outputs are each an instance. In a transformative competitive format, the rulebook is the smallest of the surfaces that shape the participant's experience. The real work of design sits in the apparatus that surrounds it: the roles participants inhabit, the stances they take toward those roles, the agencies the rules authorize, the peer economy that awards recognition, the evaluative practices that witness growth, and the governance structure that decides, over time, what the rulebook is taken to mean. Transformative game design theory has been built in contexts where that apparatus is thin—LARP weekends, indie tabletop sessions, play spaces where the designer's specification reaches the participant with minimal mediation. Competitive debate has a dense apparatus, and what this thesis offers is the beginning of a vocabulary for designing it.

That vocabulary appears in three registers. First, seven theoretical extensions, each locating a piece of the apparatus: genre alibi as the filter that decides which framings the container will accept; the judge-as-average-person as the mechanism that drives value convergence regardless of individual judges' backgrounds; steering as the construct that lets a player hold a role both from inside and from outside; Nguyen's agency-shaping as the altitude at which Bogost's procedural rhetoric becomes most clearly visible; social recognition as a third source of transformational pressure alongside competition and progression; growth legibility as the designable surface without which the debrief cannot reinforce what the play produces; and governance structure as the layer that decides, over time, what any ruleset is taken to mean. Second, five modular components of *Inside Out*—the commendation system, the split between an in-debate Interlocutor and an external Evaluator, three teams, a judge who roleplays a specific named character, and value-prescribed teams with solution freedom—each transplantable into existing formats without rewriting their rulebooks. Third, the demonstration that the intersection of game design scholarship and forensics pedagogy is productive terrain, precisely because competitive debate's institutional density makes visible an apparatus that softer play contexts never force the designer to see. The thesis's most durable invitation is therefore not to adopt *Inside Out*, but to treat the apparatus surrounding a competitive format as the real designable object, and to bring game designers into the work of shaping it.

What this thesis carries forward, then, is not a finished format but three things that are arguably more durable: a set of insights about transformative debate formats that outlast any one design; my emotional momentum required to pursue the subsequent stages of reform that the design itself cannot deliver; and evidence, however preliminary, that releasing game designers into the problem space of debate is a move worth making at the scale of the field. Snider's lineage held the insight that debate is a game played for transformation; the work he pointed to without undertaking was the work of designing debate as one would design any other game. Opening that work to game designers—and inviting the debate community to take seriously what they produce—is the lasting invitation this thesis hopes to extend.

Annex A — Inside Out Debate Format: First Design Iteration

The **Inside Out** format is an experimental debate format, designed using best practices from tabletop RPG game design. It seeks to be a more *fun*, *performance-growth oriented*, and *real-life skill-building* alternative to traditional competitive debate formats. Rather than winning arguments, debaters explore values, make meaningful decisions, and earn recognition for the skills they demonstrate.

8.0.1 Team Structure

Debaters are organised in four teams of two debaters each and are assigned positions within the debate at random:

- **Team S (Subject):** Represents the Subject of the Motion — the person who must face a decision. Must weigh all values and choose.
- **Teams A, B, and C (Value Defenders):** Each argues that a particular Value held by the Subject should be prioritised in the decision, and consequently, what the Subject should decide.

8.0.2 The Motion

The Motion outlines:

- What is the decision that has to be made.
- What is the background of the Subject and other relevant practical factors that can be taken into account within the decision.
- What are the three Values of the Subject, each assigned to one Value Defender team.

It is important to note that the Motion does not prescribe to the Value Defenders a particular position on what decision the Subject has to make. They have to construct it themselves.

8.0.3 Speech Order

The four teams hold alternating speeches in the following order:

A1, B1, C1, S1, A2, B2, C2, S2

Within their speeches, the Value Defenders argue for the relevance of their value, construct a specific decision that best honours it, and engage with the arguments forwarded by the other Value Defenders.

Within their speeches, the Subject team must outline a strong reasoning that engages with and explains the interplay between all arguments of the Value Defenders, picking a particular decision. Within S1 they pick a preliminary decision and within S2 a final decision.

8.0.4 Evaluation

The debate is overseen by an Evaluator, who performs two tasks:

Commendations. The Evaluator awards Commendations to debaters. Commendations represent acknowledgements of useful skills, knowledges, or attitudes. A list of awardable commendations is constructed by the Chief Evaluators of the Debate Tournament, along with the total number of Commendations that Evaluators can offer within that Tournament. Example commendations include Believable Passion, Witty Solution, Argument Ingenuity, and Resilience (see Section 9 of this Annex for the full list).

Over time, debaters who gather a particular commendation at least three times earn a Badge. Gathering it additional times upgrades the badge, an unlimited number of times, but each upgrade requires gathering three more Commendations than last time.

Oral Feedback. The Evaluator delivers an Oral Feedback session, in which they explain to each team the commendations they received, the reasoning behind them, and give advice on how each debater can improve in the future based on their performance.

8.0.5 Example Motion

You are the parent of a 16-year-old teenager. Your family is middle class and lives in the suburbia of a metropolis. You have higher education. You live in a country in which Higher Education is free, but there are only a few universities that are deemed as good. The year is 2026. You evaluate that your kid is talented in music, is a good leader and has had very good STEM skills, but is also quite distracted, does not have many friends and has failed to learn a foreign language. Your kid expressed a moderate interest in studying Musicology at university after they finish high school, but is also considering not going to higher education. You have a good relationship with your child. They asked you to suggest what they should do. What do you recommend your kid they should do after they finish high school?

Three Beliefs that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:

- In life, financial stability and independence is essential for a happy life.
- It is important to be a well-rounded, cultured individual.
- The people that you surround yourself with end up defining who you are.

8.0.6 Comparison with Traditional Formats

The table below contrasts Inside Out with World Schools debate along six dimensions.

	World Schools	Inside Out
Teams	2 teams $\times$ 3 members	4 teams $\times$ 2 members
Sides	Proposition vs. Opposition	3 Value Defenders + 1 Subject
Motion style	“This House...” policy/value motions	Personal dilemma with background & values
Goal	Win the argument — defeat the other side	Explore values — help the Subject decide
Evaluation	Scored on Content, Style & Strategy (points)	Commendations for skills & attitudes (badges)
Outcome	Win / Loss + speaker rankings	No win/loss — growth-oriented feedback

Key shift: Inside Out moves from adversarial persuasion to collaborative deliberation. There is no winner — instead, debaters earn commendations that recognise individual skills, and the Subject synthesises all perspectives into a reasoned decision.

8.0.7 Player Instructions

Value Defenders.

- Formulate arguments for why your value is **important, useful, and relevant** to this dilemma.
- Propose a **specific decision** that best honours your value — argue why it is right and leads to good outcomes, especially through the lens of your value.
- Engage with other Defenders’ **values**: show yours is more important, more relevant to the dilemma, or safer to follow.
- Engage with other Defenders’ **decisions**: attack, support (claiming it maximises your value), or endorse with addendums — choose your positioning wisely.
- Your core mission: **define what honouring your value looks like** in practice, and persuade the Subject it is the right path.

The Subject.

- **Enter without an opinion.** You are completely torn — you are here to listen and be persuaded, not to argue.
- Listen as if you *are* the Subject: **let the speeches move you** as they would move this person.
- Also take a mental step back: **evaluate how persuasive each argument would be** for the Subject, and adjust your lean accordingly.

- Take notes on arguments and their interplay — record what the Defenders say, **not your own personal thoughts**.
- **Collaborate quietly** with your partner: you are both embodying the same person, not competing.
- In your speeches, share which decision you are leaning toward and **why**, weighing all arguments to the extent they were persuasive. You must pick a specific decision, not merely name a value.

The Evaluator.

- Analyse the debate and each player’s performance. Decide which **commendations** to award — aim for one per debater (the same commendation can go to more than one person).
- Approach the round as an **educator** helping each player grow, not as a judge declaring a winner.
- Open with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Close by **awarding commendations** to each player.

8.0.8 Rituals

Rolling In.

1. **Team commitment chant** — Each team member states their commitment aloud before the debate begins:

Subject: *“I am [character name]. I am open to being moved.”*

Each Defender: *“I believe in [value]. I will argue from that belief.”*

Rolling Out.

1. **Subject’s thanks** — The Subject team thanks each Defender individually: *“Thank you for speaking your truth.”*
2. **Defenders’ thanks** — Each Defender team thanks the Subject: *“Thank you for listening and carrying the decision.”*

3. **De-roling** — Everyone stands. Each person states their real name and shakes hands with every participant: *“I am [name]. Thank you for playing with me.”*
4. **Bleed check** — The Evaluator asks quietly: *“Did anything in that debate feel close to home for anyone?”* — a brief, optional moment to name any emotional residue before moving into feedback. No one is required to answer.

8.0.9 Full Commendation List

Commendations are organised across five categories. Each commendation has three award tiers: *Earned* (threshold quality), *Strong* (clear excellence), and *Exceptional* (reserved for outstanding, rare performances). Some commendations carry role restrictions (Defenders only, or Subject only) as noted.

Style (*6 commendations — delivery, presence, and rhetorical quality*)

Believable Passion. You were truly invested in your point, showing genuine, believable conviction and care for the value you defended. Distinct from Honest Connection (self-disclosure) and Broad Range (technical delivery control).

Earned Tone conveyed genuine care at key moments; voice quality shifted naturally, eye contact held at key claims, word choices felt spontaneous.

Strong Conviction was felt in the substance of the speech; the room or the Subject visibly reacted.

Exceptional The delivery made the dilemma feel real and worth deeply caring about. Reserve for speeches where the affective dimension was genuinely transformative.

Entertaining Discourse. The speech was genuinely enjoyable through wit, lightness, or a well-timed observation that made the room smile or lean in. Distinct from Poetic Appeal (literary craft).

Earned At least one moment was distinctly enjoyable: a clever comparison, a light touch, or a well-timed observation.

Strong Liveliness was woven into the argumentation consistently; humor or vividness served to make points land more effectively.

Exceptional Entertainment and argument were seamlessly fused throughout, reaching the level of a sharp public talk where wit and substance were inseparable.

Broad Range. Your delivery showed impressive stylistic range, varying tone, rhythm, tempo, and volume to serve the speech. Distinct from Believable Passion (authenticity of feeling); rewards technical delivery control.

Earned At least two noticeably different delivery registers were used; the speech did not feel flat.

Strong Variation was deliberate and purposeful: shifts in pace or tone coincided with structural moments in the argument.

Exceptional The full palette was deployed with mastery; the debater controlled the room's attention through delivery alone.

Honest Connection. Something genuine about yourself entered the speech — a real disclosure rather than a rhetorical move — that created contact between the debater and the room. Distinct from Believable Passion (conviction); rewards self-disclosure and personal presence.

Earned At least one moment of genuine self-disclosure (an admission, first-person reflection, or personal statement of feeling) that felt real rather than strategic.

Strong The personal register appeared at key structural moments; eye contact moved around the room, direct second-person address, or deliberate pause.

Exceptional The speech was uniquely theirs; you felt the debater was genuinely present in the room with you.

Poetic Appeal. Language was used with aesthetic care, where rhythm, imagery, or metaphor elevated the speech as a piece of writing, independent of its entertainment value. Distinct from Entertaining Discourse (enjoyment response); rewards literary and rhetorical craft.

Earned At least one passage was noticeably well-crafted: a sentence that would stand alone as good writing, or a rhythmic construction that made a point feel inevitable.

Strong Poetic quality sustained across multiple moments; rhetoric served the argument.

Exceptional The speech had genuine literary quality; specific lines are still in your head afterward. Language itself became part of the argument.

True Embodiment. You convincingly inhabited your role, arguing and deciding from inside it rather than about it from outside. For the Subject: thinking, feeling, and deciding as the character. For Defenders: arguing from genuine conviction in the value.

Earned The role's reality guided the speech throughout; stated leanings tracked the actual arguments made.

Strong The embodiment elevated the entire round; you could see the speaker being moved, reconsidering, weighing.

Exceptional Not applicable; omit Exceptional tier for this commendation.

Strategy (*7 commendations — positioning, framing, and tactical intelligence*)

Specific Topicality. Arguments were sharply specific to this dilemma, this Subject, and these values, with no generic claims. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (evaluative lens); rewards the content of the arguments themselves.

Earned Most substantive claims grounded in the specifics of the motion: the Subject's background, the values as stated, the actual decision at stake.

Strong Topicality was strategic; the debater drew on details others missed.

Exceptional Every substantive move calibrated to this specific situation; the arguments would fall apart if the Subject or dilemma were changed.

Advantageous Framing. You defined the terms of discussion in a way that benefited your position before others could. Distinct from Specific Topicality (argument content) and Helpful Guiding (neutral Subject navigation).

Earned Explicitly established a coherent evaluation framework relevant to their value's claim.

Strong The framing did real structural work; other debaters had to address it, and the Subject engaged with it directly.

Exceptional The framing was original and visibly influenced the course of the debate. Award rarely.

Witty Solution. You proposed a concrete, value-informed solution to the dilemma, specific enough that it could only have come from someone defending your value. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (criteria); rewards the solution itself.

Earned The proposed solution was specific and thought through, demonstrably flowing from the defended value.

Strong Notably smart: navigated a genuine tension between values, or revealed an angle others missed.

Exceptional Elegant and surprising, more persuasive than alternatives precisely because of how the value was applied.

Brave Pivot. You changed position or conceded a point honestly, and it made your case stronger.

Earned Explicitly acknowledged an opponent's point had merit, or adjusted position in response to what was said.

Strong The pivot was strategic: conceding less important ground to better defend more important ground.

Exceptional Changed their mind in real time under pressure, arguing why the pivot extends rather than contradicts the previous position. Award with corresponding rarity.

Efficient Alliance. (*Defenders only*) You recognized when another Defender's arguments complemented yours and built on that alignment.

Earned Acknowledged at least one point of genuine agreement with another Defender that strengthens the case for a decision.

Strong Explicitly constructed an alliance: "both Team A and I agree that X, which shows the Subject that the weight of argument points toward Y."

Careful Positioning. (*Defenders only*) Your stance toward other Defenders' decisions was deliberate and chosen rather than reactive, with positive effect.

Earned Response to other Defenders' decisions was evidently chosen rather than accidental; the stance was coherently maintained.

Strong Positioning was in service of a coherent strategy; you could reconstruct the reasoning behind every stance taken, forming a consistent picture.

Helpful Guiding. (*Subject only*) You helped the room navigate the structure of the debate clearly, accurately, and fairly. Distinct from Advantageous Framing; the Subject's role is neutral navigation, not partisan framing.

Earned At least one moment of genuine meta-level navigation, e.g. "the key question before us is now X, because Y has been established and Z has been challenged."

Strong The guiding was structurally important, identifying a genuine turning point or consolidating arguments fairly to all sides.

Content (*9 commendations — argumentation, analysis, and engagement with the debate*)

Word Economy. You communicated clearly and efficiently; every minute of speaking time counted. Rewards form of expression, not argument substance.

Earned The speech did not waste significant time; arguments were stated without excessive preamble, redundant restatement, or filler.

Strong Concision actively served clarity: complex ideas were expressed with precision; understood fully on first hearing.

Exceptional The debater said something hard to say in few words; specific lines had a density of meaning that rewarded attention.

Rebuttal Ingenuity. Your rebuttal identified a non-obvious flaw in an opponent’s argument: a hidden assumption, internal tension, or unconsidered consequence. Distinct from Argument Ingenuity (novel constructive arguments) and Comprehensive Breadth (coverage).

Earned Identified a non-obvious weakness rather than the first available attack.

Strong Engaged with the strongest version of the argument and demonstrated why it fails even there.

Exceptional Changed the argumentative landscape; the rebuttal was difficult or impossible to satisfactorily respond to.

Rebuttal Prioritization. You made deliberate, strategic choices about where to concentrate your rebuttal effort, and those choices were correct. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (coverage); rewards deliberate focus over breadth.

Earned Concentrated force on the most important clashes, explicitly or implicitly flagging the allocation.

Strong Prioritization revealed genuine strategic intelligence; the choice of what to ignore was as deliberate as what was attacked.

Rebuttal Accuracy. You represented opponents’ arguments faithfully before responding — no mischaracterization, no straw-manning. No Exceptional tier; accuracy is a threshold quality. Award only when faithful representation was genuinely non-trivial.

Earned Paraphrased opponents’ arguments correctly; engaged with the most charitable understanding.

Strong Engaged with specific moments in specific speeches; accuracy made the rebuttal more effective, not just fairer.

Robust Logic. Your arguments were well-constructed: valid, plausible, and without significant logical gaps. Distinct from Impressive Argumentative Depth; logic asks whether the reasoning chain holds structurally.

Earned Main arguments had clear claim-warrant-impact structure; a reasonable person could follow without supplying missing steps.

Strong Logic held up under challenge: no internal contradictions, no steps requiring the audience to take things on faith.

Exceptional Genuinely tight; would require a sophisticated objection to dislodge; obvious objections anticipated within the argument itself.

Impressive Argumentative Depth. You went beyond the surface, interrogating implications, mechanisms, or philosophical roots. Distinct from Robust Logic (structural soundness) and Argument Ingenuity (novelty).

Earned At least one argument went meaningfully beyond its initial claim, explaining why the value’s demand is well-founded or what it would look like for the Subject to live by it.

Strong Depth sustained throughout; consistently pushed past surface-level argumentation.

Exceptional After the speech, you found yourself reconsidering something you had assumed you understood, or the argument illuminated a dimension of the value no other speech had touched.

Comprehensive Breadth. You engaged with the full scope of the debate, including inconvenient arguments. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (sharpness) and Rebuttal Prioritization (deliberate focus); rewards attentiveness across the full debate.

Earned Addressed the most important arguments from all other Defenders, not only the weakest or most convenient.

Strong Demonstrated careful listening throughout; the speech reflected the actual state of the debate.

Exceptional Managed to synthetically yet explicitly cover every significant aspect of the debate.

Argument Ingenuity. You produced an argument that was unexpected, non-obvious, and substantively illuminating. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (reactive) and Impressive Argumentative Depth (thorough development); rewards novelty and surprise.

Earned At least one argument was notably fresh: not typically heard in this kind of debate, logically coherent, and able to withstand an obvious first objection.

Strong Ingenious in the full sense: first surprised you, then convinced you, revealing something about the value or dilemma that prior thinking had missed.

Exceptional The argument changed the debate; others had to respond to it and it became a fixed reference point. Very rare, award accordingly.

Accurate Synthesis. (*Subject only*) You gave a fair, accurate, and well-organized account of the full state of the debate. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (Defenders’ engagement); rewards the Subject for faithfully describing and weighing what happened.

Earned Correctly identified the main arguments from each Defender and did not misrepresent or omit them, even where unfavorable.

Strong Showed genuine comprehension of the debate’s structure: an account of how arguments interacted, where they clashed, and what the real decision points were.

Exceptional Identified the strongest and weakest versions of each Defender’s case and grounded the final decision in a genuinely comprehensive account of the round.

Fairplay (*3 commendations — observe team dynamics & debrief, not only speeches*)

Teammate Support. You actively helped your partner formulate something difficult in a way that visibly contributed to the team’s performance. Look for: visible collaboration during prep time; a second speaker building clearly on something the first struggled with. Award when the help was substantive and its impact visible. Ask in the debrief if not fully observable.

Teammate Solidarity. You showed genuine support for your partner during a hard moment, without distancing yourself. Look for: body language and verbal behavior toward a partner after a difficult moment; a second speaker who picked up where a struggling first left off without implicitly throwing them under the bus. The difficult moment must have been real and the solidarity genuine. If ambiguous, ask in the debrief.

Strategic Problem-Solving. You demonstrated intelligent, adaptive problem-solving in the face of strategic challenges in the round. Look for: a visible strategy adjustment that worked; a debater who recognized a weakness in their own case and addressed it explicitly; coordinated strategic adaptation across both speeches. Both identifying and solving the problem must be visible and shared between the two team members.

Growth Mentality (*4 commendations — use the debrief; always name the specific moment in feedback*)

Applied Feedback. You visibly tried to apply feedback from a previous round; imperfect application still earns this. Evidence may come from direct comparison with a prior round or from the debater’s own account in the debrief. What matters is the genuine attempt rather than the outcome.

Out of Comfort Zone. You attempted something genuinely difficult for you and made a real go of it. Rewards the attempt, not the result. Comfort zone is individual; use the debrief to identify what was genuinely challenging. Ask directly if needed.

Tracking. You showed clear awareness of your own growth across debates: where you started, what you have worked on, and where you are heading. Distinct from Applied Feedback (applying specific feedback in one round); rewards the broader self-awareness of one’s development arc over time. Evidence may come from the debrief: the debater can articulate what they have improved, name skills still being worked on, and describe their trajectory with accuracy.

Resilience. You encountered a genuinely difficult moment and came out intact, or stronger. The difficult moment must have been real. Award for: a strong attack responded to with a composed second speech; a delivery stumble overcome mid-speech; an unexpected move handled with adaptability. Name the specific moment in feedback; this commendation must be concrete to be useful.

Annex B — Inside Out Debate Format: Second Design Iteration

The second design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the first playtest (Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026). See Annex F for a detailed first playtest report. The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the first iteration (Annex A).

8.0.10 Speech Order Changes

The interstitial S1 speech between the first and second rounds is removed. In its place, two new elements are introduced:

S0 — Subject Opening Speech. A new opening speech before any Defender speaks. The Subject team introduces the dilemma and argues why it is genuinely hard: all three values are relevant, the decision is real, and there is no obvious right answer. This speech gives the debate proper gravitas before Defenders begin.

The Huddle. A 10-minute interval inserted after C1 (and before A2). The Subject team may ask direct questions to any Defender team, grant them the floor to answer, and revoke their right to speak at any point. The Huddle allows the Subject to control the conversation toward resolving argumentative tensions, forcing arguments that need to interact to interact.

Thinking Time. A 2-minute silent thinking period is added before S2, giving the Subject team time to integrate all arguments before delivering their final decision.

The new speech order is:

S0, A1, B1, C1, [The Huddle], A2, B2, C2, [2-min thinking time], S2

Points of Information (POIs) are introduced during all speeches: any debater may signal to the current speaker to ask a brief question.

8.0.11 Motion Changes

- The Subject character description in the motion should include a longer list of the Subject’s personal beliefs and past decisions, to flesh out the character more fully and enable value-specific argumentation.
- Value Defenders should address the Subject in the second person (“you, as the Subject, should...”) rather than in the third person, reinforcing the personal and direct character of the deliberation.

8.0.12 Evaluation Changes

Commendations are awarded in private: after the debate, the Evaluator approaches each team separately rather than delivering commendations in a public session. The oral feedback narrative and growth-oriented debrief remain public.

8.0.13 Speech Instruction Clarifications

- Subject instructions explicitly state that the Subject must pick a specific *decision* (a concrete course of action), not merely name a value they find most important.
- More explicit guidance is provided on what the Subject team should prepare during prep time: for S0, they should prepare to explain the dilemma’s genuine difficulty and why all values are relevant; for S2, they should prepare to synthesise all arguments and justify a final specific decision.

Annex C — Debrief Form

The following questionnaire was administered to participants after the first playtest. Questions aim to gather data on entertainment value, format distinctiveness, participant intentions, and transformative effects.

1. How fun was the debate? (scale 1–10)
2. How fun was it compared to a debate in a traditional format? (5-choice scale)
3. Was there anything surprisingly entertaining or engaging about it?
4. Was there anything about the format that was quite difficult, to the point of frustration?
5. Was there anything about the rules of the format that was confusing?
6. Would you play this format some more? (Yes / No)
7. If you would play it some more, in what circumstance would you?
8. If there was to exist an alternative debate circuit centred around this format, would you attend those competitions? Even at the expense of competitions in the WS or BP format?
9. Do you believe you played differently than you would have in a debate in WS/BP with a rather similar motion? If so, how?
10. Do you feel different than how you usually feel after a debate? If so, how?
11. Did you perceive yourself and others speaking similarly or differently than how you do in a regular debate? If so, how?
12. Were you to redo this debate, what would you do differently?
13. Were you to play more in this format, but on different motions, what would you do differently?
14. What do you believe you learned from this debate?
15. What do you believe this debate format does better, as a learning/empowerment tool, than WS or BP? Do you believe it does something worse?

Annex D — Playtest Motion

The following motion was used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

First version. Used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

You are Alex. You are a lawyer. You are close to your older brother Matei. He is a very caring person to everyone, always eager to help even strangers. He always helped you when you were in need. However he was always quite dishonest with you, and you caught him lying even about important things. Matei is also an alcoholic and you believe he is quite bigoted.

Matei was involved in a hit and run recently. He hit a cyclist that ended up hospitalised. The cyclist remembered his license plate only partially and he is now being investigated by the police. From your knowledge they only have circumstantial evidence, but he still risks going to jail. He asked you to lie that he was with you at home at the time of the accident, in order to provide him an alibi. Your assessment as a lawyer is that this will almost certainly exonerate him. However, a very small risk remains that additional material evidence could be found, at which point you might become an accessory to the crime.

What should you do?

Three Values that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:

- You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
- You believe in justice: that people should receive what they deserve.
- You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Second version. Used in the second playtest, April 2026.

Alex is a criminal defence lawyer with seven years of experience. The eldest of three siblings from a small town, Alex was the first in the family to attend law school. After graduating, Alex spent two years at a legal aid clinic representing clients who could not afford private counsel, before joining a private firm. Alex's first major case there was defending a driver charged with causing serious injury in a road accident — Alex secured his acquittal.

Matei is Alex's older brother and the two have remained close throughout their lives. Matei is known among everyone who knows him for being eager to help others, often going out of his way even for strangers. He helped Alex through several difficult periods. He has also been dishonest with Alex repeatedly over the years, including about important matters. Matei struggles with alcohol and holds a number of views that Alex finds bigoted.

Matei was recently involved in a hit-and-run: he struck a cyclist who was hospitalised. The cyclist recalled his license plate only partially, and Matei is now under police investigation. As far as Alex knows, the evidence against him is circumstantial. Matei has asked Alex to lie and say he was at home with Alex at the time of the accident. Alex's legal assessment is that this would almost certainly exonerate him, though a small risk remains that additional material evidence could surface — at which point Alex would become an accessory to the crime. **What should you do?**

Values:

1. You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
2. You believe in justice, that people should receive what they deserve.
3. You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Annex E — Informed Consent Form

I, _____ of _____ years of age, voluntarily accept to participate in a playtest followed by an interview session, both moderated by Andrei Dan Olaru, as part of his “*Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate*” study. This study seeks to explore the creation of an alternative debate format, informed by modern transformative game design theory. I understand that:

1. This session implies video recording of the entire debate playtest and the subsequent collective interview, plus some additional questions using an online questionnaire.
2. Pseudonyms will be used when analysing the data for confidentiality, and the researchers commit to not revealing the identities of the participants. Individual raw data may be discussed in class or with the supervisor without the participant’s name to trace back to. The data obtained will be analysed by grouping and some textual examples will be used anonymously.
3. The recording will be safely stored in the university’s OneDrive to maintain the saved raw interviews protected. The video will be erased one month after the dissertation’s results. The transcripts will be erased up to one year after the dissertation’s results.
4. None of the questions will go against my integrity, no harm will come to me during this session, no answer is right or wrong and I may choose not to answer any question(s) without consequences of any kind.
5. I am free to walk out of the playtest and interview at any time if I deem it necessary without prejudice or any consequences.

For any additional information or difficulty, the participant may contact the researcher Andrei Dan Olaru at `andrei-dan.olaru.0744@student.uu.se`.

Participant’s signature

Researcher’s signature

I, _____ have been informed of the conditions and freely accept to participate in the research by Andrei Dan Olaru.

Participant’s signature

_____ of March
2026
Date

Annex F — First Playtest Report

The following is a first-person account of the first playtest session, held in March 2026 at the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest. The session gathered six senior debaters (aged 18–20). Design changes arising from this playtest are documented separately in Annex B.

8.0.14 Setting and Participants

The playtest involved six senior debaters from the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest, all aged between 18 and 20. These were experienced debaters, though none had encountered the Inside Out format before. I facilitated the session as the Evaluator and observed throughout.

8.0.15 The Brief

The brief took approximately 40 minutes. The format was significantly different enough from traditional debate that this length of explanation was necessary even for experienced players. Participants had many questions, particularly about two elements: (1) how the Subject role works and the roleplay dimension, which was described as “the newest and most different part of the format”, and (2) whether counter-argumentation between Value Defenders is permitted — a question I found somewhat surprising in hindsight.

8.0.16 Preparation Time

During prep time, the players struggled to figure out what to prepare. This was the first indication that the format demands a fundamentally different kind of preparation than traditional debate. Unlike preparing a policy or value case for traditional formats, players needed to figure out how to approach the Subject’s dilemma through the lens of a specific value.

8.0.17 Rituals

The roll-in rituals felt awkward and cringe to participants. The rituals themselves were lengthy and formalized, which created discomfort rather than appropriate atmosphere-setting. More effective would be a brief introduction by the Evaluator followed by a small gesture or shared chant that everyone performs together.

Notably, the players did recognize and appreciate that the rituals acknowledged the effort and role of the judge — in this case shared between the Evaluator and Subject.

The calling rituals (used to introduce each speaker) were received positively and did not require revision.

The roll-out rituals also felt overly lengthy and became cringe. However, one participant noted they appreciated the moment of collective gratitude that the rituals attempted to create. A simpler version involving handshakes and brief role-specific phrases would likely work better.

8.0.18 Speech Flow and Embodiment

An interesting pattern emerged across the speeches: players began using World Schools parliamentary plural and third-person references early on, but speech by speech, they naturally shifted toward second-person address and self-identification with the Subject’s values. One player would say “we believe” at the start of their first speech, but by the second round was saying “I believe in this value” and referring to the Subject directly as “you.”

This raised an important design question: should the Value Defenders fully embody the voice of the value (speaking as if they are an inner voice of the Subject themselves), or should they position themselves as advisors speaking about the Subject in the second person? The natural drift toward the former suggests players intuitively moved toward stronger roleplay embodiment, but the rules should be clarified on this point.

8.0.19 First Round of Value Defenders

Players immediately grasped that they needed to argue for the importance and relevance of their assigned value to the dilemma. They picked up on the fact that the solutions offered could be complex, realistic, and nuanced — distinct from traditional debate solutions.

However, the distinction between arguing for a value and proposing a decision remained fuzzy for many. The fact that they must “pick a solution and not necessarily a value” was confusing initially; the rules require clarification and possibly example mini-speeches illustrating this distinction.

8.0.20 Argumentation Style

The format demands a form of argumentation that is fundamentally different from traditional debate. Rather than constructing large-scale causal chains and impact scenarios, Value Defenders must argue for their values on their own terms — their importance, their weight in the decision, their interaction with other values. This was hard for players: it is uncommon in World Schools or BP debate, and finding “more things to say” about values themselves (as opposed to practical outcomes) required a different cognitive mode.

One significant observation: players felt the Subject character needed to be more fully fleshed out. The richer the characterization — the beliefs they hold, decisions they have made in the past, their personality — the easier it would be for Value Defenders to construct arguments tailored to that specific person’s identity and narrative consistency. Players noted that this reflects how people actually construct their own identities: by looking at the coherence of their past actions and trying to remain narratively consistent.

8.0.21 Participant Experience

Despite the challenges, or perhaps because of them, participants reported the format to be surprisingly liberating. They reported feeling “a lot less anxiety” than in traditional debate, while also finding the work “actually very complex and interesting strategically.” They noted that architecting solutions was intellectually demanding in a different way: every detail of the context became potential argumentative material rather than merely setting for claims about large-scale consequences.

One highly competitive player — the type that “usually wins a lot at competitions” — reported finding the format less exhilarating. They felt that the cooperative nature took away from the “thrill of collegial competitive jabbing” and the “adrenaline of winning,” making the overall experience feel “anticlimactic.” This was a useful signal: the format appears to function as an alternative to traditional debate rather than a replacement, appealing to different motivations than ego-driven competitive success.

8.0.22 Recognized Format Distinctiveness

Players articulated several ways in which the format plays differently:

- Explaining long, mechanistic causal chains is less necessary because there is no need to think through large-scale consequences (though such thinking could still occur if the dilemma involved someone with power over others).
- The power to formulate solutions makes it easier to stay topical and makes the whole debate less vague — the debate becomes about real dilemmas rather than abstract policy positions.
- It is less about proving large-scale third-order impacts and more about navigating genuine tensions between values.

Players reported speaking more slowly but with similar theatricality to traditional debate, contrary to expectations. Though some initially felt they spoke more monotonously, other participants who reported understanding that the Subject could be emotionally moved as well noted they were quite theatrical and expressive. Some said that were they to debate again, they would try to be more emotionally immersed, consciously shifting away from trying to be very “sweaty” toward winning.

8.0.23 Reported Learning and Growth

When asked what they believed they had learned, participants identified several insights:

- The format teaches you to be more relaxed and to enjoy playing.
- It teaches you to think about the context of decisions rather than abstractly applying rules.
- It makes you more human and more honest about human nature.
- It engages with the identity of decision-making: the recognition that “every team says valuable stuff and it is important more rather to see what is important to us.”
- This last point led to a striking reflection: that sometimes decisions are not universal, they are personal, and arguing that someone is morally wrong when deciding or believing something is a bit absurd.

Some participants felt the format is more suitable for beginners than for highly competitive debaters. I agree with the latter assessment but also believe that with a more complex motion, experienced debaters could recognize how the format could be played at higher skill levels.

8.0.24 Participant Feedback on Rules

Many participants requested the addition of Points of Information (POIs) — brief interjections during speeches. This became a high-priority feature request.

The participants also noted that the Subject role needs explicit scaffolding during preparation time. Rather than leaving this open, it would be helpful to have them prepare a first speech in which they explain the dilemma, why it is so hard, and how all values are relevant. Giving the dilemma “real gravitas” — proving to everyone that the decision is truly important and truly hard — would set the stage more effectively.

8.0.25 Observational Notes and Design Recommendations

Several design improvements emerged from observation:

- **Ritual for calling people:** A more natural, shorter ritual is needed between speeches to call in the next speaker.
- **Subject preparation:** Give the Subject team something concrete to do during prep time: prepare a first speech that explains the dilemma and its difficulty, establishing that all values are genuinely relevant.
- **Motion design:** Include a longer list of things the Subject believes about themselves and decisions they have made in the past. This supports more specific, character-tailored argumentation by the Value Defenders.
- **Speech instructions:** Make explicit instructions clearer, particularly on the distinction between defending a value and proposing a solution, and on whether Value Defenders should embody an “inner voice” of the Subject or position themselves as advisors.
- **Interstitial speech:** Consider whether an interstitial speech between the first and second rounds of Value Defenders might help reset the debate or provide needed structure. (This was later addressed in subsequent iterations by introducing the Huddle.)

Annex G — Second Playtest Report

The following is a first-person account of the second playtest session, held in April 2026. The session gathered seven veteran debaters. Design changes arising from this playtest are documented separately in Annex H.

8.0.26 Setting

I held the second playtest together with seven veteran debaters, close friends. We held it at the apartment that part of us commonly rent and share with other nerds for the single purpose of playing TTRPGs there. Because of that, the main room is dominated by a hilariously large, roughly round table. We held the debate seated at it, which one player noted created a council-feel to the whole session — as opposed to a regular debate in which the seating mimics parliamentary discourse and thus feels profoundly more impersonal. I was not the Evaluator this time; I played as the second speaker of the A Inner Voice team.

8.0.27 The Brief

The brief took about 40 minutes — similar to how much it took with the high-schoolers. The fact that it required that amount of time even with people accustomed to parsing lengthy rulebooks speaks to how much the design differs from traditional formats. The division of the “judge” role into two separate individuals (the Subject and the Evaluator) was noted as interesting by several players. The role of the Subject was by far the hardest for players to understand, especially the purpose of the opening Subject speech. I had, at the point of writing the rules, found it genuinely difficult to pin down what the Subject should do in that first speech. I wrote vague guidelines — and this showed — but in the end I believe it was for the better: I let the player decide what would be most interesting and useful. In that I was fortunate: the role was drawn by a player with substantial game-design experience, a professional L&D background, many years as a trainer, and deep experience as a roleplayer.

8.0.28 Rituals

The roll-in rituals were experienced as cringe, and were surely too lengthy. Players felt they should be replaced by a short introduction from the Evaluator followed by a brief shared gesture or chant. This aligns with how regular debates open: the judge makes an introduction, then everyone bangs the table vigorously and the debate begins. One player noted that the rituals do recognise the effort put in by the judge — in this case shared between the Subject and the Evaluator.

The calling rituals were received positively.

The roll-out rituals were also too lengthy and became cringe, but one player noted they liked the way in which people express gratitude to everyone. The consensus was that this could be replaced by a moment of handshakes in which each person says a short phrase based on their role. Players also noted that calling a defender by name during the calling ritual felt unnecessary.

8.0.29 S0 — The Opening Subject Speech

The player who drew the Subject role delivered an interesting, roleplay-heavy speech — they even played a soundtrack. They fleshed out the motion with many evocative details that further emotionally contextualised the scenario, then tried to explain how they care about all three values and why each is relevant to the decision. This in part exposed some nuanced personal biases that bled from the player into the character. Several players — including that player — noted that this institutionalises the already existing practice of debaters “playing for the judge”: attempting to exploit the judge’s known biases. I found this observation striking. The speech, although I was sceptical of it initially, does hold a great deal of value: fleshing out the scenario, giving a floor for surfacing biases. What it needs is clearer language for what players are supposed to do.

8.0.30 First Round of Inner Voices

All players immediately adopted a roleplay stance. They spoke directly to the Subject, addressing them by name and in the second person, looking at them, and choosing speech patterns that mirrored those the Subject had displayed. They also took the liberty to add small details to the motion — to worldbuild.

I find this very promising but also somewhat concerning. Giving players unofficial world-building powers may lead inexperienced players to twist the debate in an unhelpful direction. However, adding colour to the broad facts of the scenario does lend to a more realistic simulation of how people actually argue, raises emotional engagement, and heightens immersion.

It was interesting that even very veteran debaters struggled, especially in this first round, to both appeal to emotion and to argue specifically for their assigned value. Most focused on constructing interesting and nuanced Solutions and arguing why these were practical and useful — utilitarian and cerebral overall — except for the last team, who appealed explicitly to emotion, which set the tone interestingly for the second half.

Players also began referring to each other as “the other inner voices” — an organic renaming that feels more natural than “Value Defenders”. I plan to adopt it.

8.0.31 The Huddle

Everyone found the Huddle very, very fun. The Subject player later said it was a genuine eureka moment when they realised they could ask particular Inner Voices to have very specific conversations with each other. It is worth noting that this player has meeting facilitation experience. During the Huddle, the Subject first asked each team to clarify things they were still confused about, then asked teams to expand on arguments they found particularly interesting, then asked pairs of Inner Voices to directly clash on issues they felt needed resolving.

At a certain point the Subject ran out of ideas for what to ask. I believe that with two players on the Subject team this would happen less frequently. Still, ten minutes felt too long — I would cut it to eight.

8.0.32 Second Round of Inner Voices

The Huddle exacerbated something that had already started in the first round: a slow drift toward consensus on what decision should be taken. The second round was much less about the practicalities of which decision is best, and much more about arguing which is the dominant lens through which the decision should be viewed.

My intuition is that something similar might happen with other groups, not only with veteran debaters.

During my own speech I also pivoted toward consensus on the right Solution. I did this because I found it interesting and novel — something regular debate never allows — and I wanted to see how it felt, to demonstrate that the rules permit it, and to explore whether I could deliberately fish for the “Brave Pivot” commendation. I found that I felt little need to rebut the points made by others; arguing for my lens and shifting focus felt like a more natural and persuasive strategy than attacking others, and I allowed myself to be openly persuaded by fellow Inner Voices on some points.

A fellow player later noted that in this format to outright attack what others say “feels wrong” — disrespectful and unnecessary — and that the format requires tact in how one goes about diminishing the relevance of another’s points.

8.0.33 Second Subject Speech

The Subject player structured their speech quite like a regular debate adjudication: they explained what they understood each Inner Voice team to have argued and how convincing each case was, then expressed the solution they had reached and what had factored most in their decision. They later said that during the first speech they were in more of a roleplay mindframe, but that as the debate progressed they transitioned more and more to feeling and thinking like a debate judge.

My intention had been for the second speech to remain somewhat more roleplay-ish — the Subject speaking about how something *felt* persuasive, being a bit less analytical. I am not sure whether adjusting the instructions is needed, or whether this was simply the style of this particular player.

8.0.34 The Evaluator Speech

The Evaluator gave insightful feedback on how each of us could have been more persuasive to a regular person. She then noted it was very difficult to find feedback to give, because the format does not specify clearly toward what educational objectives the feedback should be directed.

This raised a broader question I should think about more: traditional debate exists within a complex, organic constellation of clubs and competitions. Most people tell themselves they do debate to learn — critical thinking, public speaking — and trainers and judges tell themselves they are there to teach useful skills. In practice, my sense is that the circuit has a life of its own, and that people invest effort on either side mostly for the social reputation it yields.

How should this format be played? Who should facilitate it? Who is it for? What should it help participants achieve?

Another interesting suggestion was that a structure allowing the Evaluator to be more actively involved — to facilitate and give real-time feedback, to encourage players — would be useful. I tend to agree. Renaming the Evaluator “the Facilitator” might help signal this.

The Evaluator also said that awarding commendations was difficult, and that in a larger circuit it would become easier: she would not feel pressure to give everyone a commendation and would reserve them for truly outstanding moments. She added that once the commendations were memorised the system would feel much more organic than the numeric speech-point quantification that most traditional formats require of judges.

8.0.35 On Bleed

I decided to skip the final bleed-releasing ritual, expecting it would feel awkward. It was interesting, then, that even without it, one of the players spontaneously shared during a brief intermission that the debate had hit uncannily close to home: on the way to the session, a family member had asked them to testify for them in court, which they had found morally wrong.

8.0.36 On Commendations

There was substantial discussion about the commendation system. The more “gamer” of the players expressed that it scratches a “make a build” itch, but felt that commendations should carry some bonuses as well. They also raised the concern that players might start farming them — choosing to play in unusual ways simply to collect a specific commendation and “complete” a build.

8.0.37 Participant Feedback

Most players expressed that the game was quite fun and that they believed it would be enjoyable even outside a casual friends setting.

One noteworthy pattern in the feedback: women and players who had been less successful as traditional debaters said they strongly preferred this format. Men who had been highly successful debaters expressed finding it less exhilarating. One participant put it directly: “There are few things more ego-boosting than the feeling of total mind-domination that you get when you win a debate, and this cannot give you that.”

One point everyone agreed on was that the format is much less anxiety-inducing than regular debate, while still providing a structure for meaningful conversation — unlike open real-life discussions, where people tend to fight over talking space.

One player suggested that the format might benefit from transitioning more wholeheartedly toward improv theatre — becoming a roleplaying game without any performance-evaluation component. Another countered that there is value in the sense that you are always progressing, at least a little, with every debate.

Annex H — Inside Out Debate Format: Third Design Iteration

The third design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the second playtest (April 2026). The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the second iteration (Annex B).

8.0.38 Role Renaming

Value Defenders are renamed Inner Voices. This name emerged organically during the second playtest, when players began referring to each other as “the other inner voices”. It better reflects the roleplay-oriented nature of the format and the relationship between the Value Defender teams and the Subject.

8.0.39 S0 — Opening Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the opening Subject speech are revised to foreground the roleplay dimension:

Hold a monologue as if you are the character, alone in a place of comfort, speaking to yourself about the dilemma. Express why this decision is truly difficult and how much getting it right matters to you. Explain why each value is relevant to this decision, and how you cannot simply disregard any of them. Do not lean toward any decision yet.

8.0.40 The Huddle

The Huddle is shortened from 10 minutes to **8 minutes**.

8.0.41 S2 — Final Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the final Subject speech are revised to include emotional closure:

Synthesise all arguments and deliver a decision over a specific solution — a concrete course of action from those presented by the Inner Voices. Explain how everything in the debate contributed to this decision; leave nothing important out. Say why you feel this is the right decision, and how you now feel about making it.

8.0.42 Seating

A seating instruction is added: try to arrange chairs so that the Inner Voices and the Subject face each other. Inner Voices speak from where they sit, standing or seated. The Subject does the same. The Evaluator sits somewhere outside the main circle — present but out of sight, out of mind.

8.0.43 Specific Times

The following timing guidelines are provided:

- **Speaking times:** 5 minutes per speech.
- **Prep time:** 30 minutes for beginners or high-school debaters; 15 minutes for experienced adults.
- **Evaluator oral critique:** 10 minutes.
- **Evaluator-led debrief:** 15 minutes.

8.0.44 Rituals

The following rituals replace those described in the first design iteration (Annex A).

Rolling In.

1. **Evaluator opens** — The Evaluator says: *“You are here to decide together.”*
2. **All respond** — Everyone answers: *“Yes, we are.”* followed by shared clapping.

Calling an Inner Voice.

1. The Evaluator calls: *“Voice, speak for [Value].”*
2. The speaker **must begin their speech** with the words *“I will. . .”*

Rolling Out.

1. **Voices’ thanks** — Each Inner Voice says: *“Thank you for listening to me.”*
2. **Subject’s thanks** — The Subject says to the Inner Voices: *“Thank you for speaking your truth.”* The Subject then says to the Evaluator: *“Thank you for listening to me.”*
3. **Bleed check** — Everyone states their real name and how they feel right now. The Evaluator then leads a brief debrief.

8.0.45 Commendation System

The commendation system is updated with a tier structure governing how commendations are distributed:

- Every debater should receive at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech. At higher levels of play, T1 commendations carry less competitive weight but remain a baseline acknowledgement of participation.
- The Evaluator has a **limited pool of T2 (Strong) and T3 (Exceptional)** commendations to offer per debate. These are awarded in private.

- Some commendations may be **exclusive to specific Evaluators**, reflecting their expertise or perspective.
- Some rounds or competitions may designate a **featured commendation** — a particular commendation given special significance in that context.

8.0.46 Evaluator Instructions

The Evaluator role is reframed toward active facilitation:

- You are the **facilitator** of the entire event. Your primary job is for everyone to feel safe and to play to grow.
- Feel free to **intervene** when it feels natural. Encourage players when you think it is necessary. Gently redirect when someone may be making others uncomfortable. Invite players out of their comfort zone when you believe it is in their best interest. Be human; establish a relationship of trust and growth with the others.
- After the debate ends, **first facilitate a brief debrief** stemming from the bleed check moment, then transition to the oral critique.
- Prepare **potential debrief questions** whilst others are preparing for the debate. Debrief questions should *not* focus (as the oral critique does) on skill growth, but rather on **meaningful emotional growth and acceptance of others' realities**. Explore how debaters would act in a similar scenario and what their own values are regarding the values explored in the debate. When in doubt, use these two anchor questions: *“How important are these values for you?”* and *“Were you in a similar scenario, what other values would influence you?”*
- Open the oral critique with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Award at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech to every debater. Use your limited pool of **T2 (Strong)** and **T3 (Exceptional)** commendations sparingly — these are awarded in private.

Annex I — Clues from Playtests

The following catalogue is the output of the three-phase systematic analysis described in the Methods chapter: initial descriptive coding of field notes and debrief responses, comparative organization around continuity, difference, and novelty, and articulation of design principles connecting mechanics to observed effects.

Unlike a traditional results catalogue—which reports only what happened—this annex is organized around a pre-defined taxonomy of *potential clues*: the observable signs that would count as evidence *for* or *against* the format’s intended effects across each evaluation field. This taxonomy was specified *before* data collection, as described in the Methods chapter, to ensure that analysis remained responsive to disconfirming evidence and did not converge only on confirming observations. For each potential clue, the catalogue records whether it was observed during the playtests, with what evidential support, and at what strength. Clues that did not manifest are recorded explicitly: the absence of a negative clue is evidence of the format functioning as intended; the absence of a positive clue is a genuine gap.

Evidence is classified by direction and strength. **Positive clues** are behaviors or reports consistent with the format achieving its intended effect. **Negative clues** are behaviors or reports indicating a design gap or failure. Strength is assessed as *Strong* (behavioral, multi-source, or unsolicited), *Moderate* (self-reported or single-source), or *Weak* (speculative or highly context-dependent). Consistent with the comparative analysis described in the Methods chapter, behavioral and emergent evidence carries more weight than self-reported responses, and novel or different behaviors (departures from standard debate practice) constitute stronger design evidence than continuities, which may reflect participants’ existing training rather than effects of the new format. Self-reported evidence gathered in response to direct questions in the semi-structured group debrief is noted where relevant, as it remains evidentially valid even if weaker than unsolicited or behavioral clues.

Sources: *P1* = First playtest field notes (Jean Monet debate club, March 2026); *P2* = Second playtest field notes (April 2026); *D1/D2* = Post-session debrief responses after first/second playtest; *T2* = Transcript of second playtest.

A note on social desirability in Field 1. Engagement and popularity clues are the most susceptible to social desirability effects: participants knew they were playtesting a format designed by the researcher in the room, and the exclusive nature of the invitation may have elevated their investment in displaying enthusiasm. Positive engagement evidence should therefore be read with additional skepticism; behavioral indicators are weighted higher than self-reports, and negative clues—which participants would have had more reason to suppress—carry elevated weight when they do appear.

Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

Positive potential clues

1. Unsolicited expressions of enthusiasm during or after the debate

Points toward: Positive affective engagement; potential for voluntary repeated participation.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Participants described the experience as “surprisingly liberating” (P1, D1) and “very very fun” during the Huddle phase (P2, D2). Multiple unprompted positive comments recorded in both debrief forms without being solicited.

Mechanic: Removal of binary win/loss outcomes, combined with out-of-sight Evaluator seating, reduces performance-oriented anxiety; personal dilemma motions create genuine stakes without threatening social standing, making organic enthusiasm more likely.

Strength: Moderate. Self-reported; subject to social desirability effects; see caveat above.

2. **Passionate or animated discussion among participants without researcher prompting**

Points toward: Genuine peer engagement; format generates internal conversational momentum.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2).

Evidence: Post-debrief conversation in both sessions extended organically beyond the structured questions. In the second playtest, participants continued discussing the motion and their own values informally after the session ended. Both sessions also produced animated group conversations specifically about the experience of using second-person direct address and personal appeals during speeches: participants in both groups noted that this mode of speaking—addressing the Subject directly as “you” and appealing to their personal circumstances—felt novel, engaging, and surprisingly enjoyable to both perform and receive.

Mechanic: Personal dilemma motions make participants’ own values directly relevant, creating natural grounds for continued conversation; the debrief structure designates and legitimizes extended reflection rather than truncating it. The second-person address mode inverts standard debate’s impersonal register, making the emotional texture of the debate itself a topic of enthusiastic reflection.

Strength: Moderate. Observed; behavioral; but also consistent with social novelty of the event.

3. **Visible engagement signals during debate itself (laughter, focused silence, forward leaning)**

Points toward: Format sustaining in-the-moment attention and flow.

Observed: Yes (P1 and P2).

Evidence: Second playtest field notes record observable engagement during speeches and very novel and creative decisions: to play background music during S1 speech, to adopt speaking accents etc. In the first playtest, as players became more aware of what they could do in the debate, they started to have more fun and more passionate speeches.

Mechanic: The Huddle phase builds emotional investment before speeches begin through interactive preparation; the Subject as a live, named decision-maker provides a concrete human target rather than an abstract adjudicator, sustaining speaker investment.

Strength: Moderate. Observational; first-playtest engagement was inconsistent.

4. **Unprompted recognition of the format’s benefits**

Points toward: Participants forming their own positive evaluation independent of researcher framing.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Multiple participants articulated benefits spontaneously: accessibility, empathy development, skill transfer, reduced anxiety. In the second playtest, there was conversation on how the format would be a useful personal development tool for “corpo trainings.”

Mechanic: Not tied to one particular mechanic but rather the format as a whole.

Strength: Moderate. Self-report; theoretically coherent; partially behavioral (the personal-development-tool framing implies intention to act).

5. **Expressed desire to replay or requests to organize future rounds**

Points toward: Replayability; format generates sustained rather than one-off interest.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1).

Evidence: Participants said they would play again and would aim to be “more emotionally immersed” next time (P1, D1). In the second playtest players reported they would find it a fun game especially to play with friends, as a passtime, and to get their “build” done.

Mechanic: The roleplay dimension of the format—emotional inhabitation of a character’s values—is recognized by participants as an unexplored skill, creating an intrinsic learning arc; the commendation system provides named targets (e.g., “Believable Passion”) for improvement across sessions.

Strength: Moderate. Self-reported intention; actual re-engagement behavior untested.

6. **High enjoyment scores when directly asked**

Points toward: Positive affective engagement; format generating a genuinely enjoyable experience rather than merely tolerable or dutiful participation.

Observed: Yes (D1, D2).

Evidence: When asked directly in the debrief form how much they enjoyed the game, participants in both sessions reported very high scores. While solicited self-report is weaker evidence than unsolicited enthusiasm, the consistently high numbers across both groups—including participants who were not particularly enthused about other aspects—indicate that the enjoyment response was not merely social desirability but genuine. The convergence with unsolicited expressions in clue 1 above strengthens the overall picture.

Mechanic: Same as clue 1.

Strength: Moderate. Direct debrief form response; subject to social desirability effects; convergent with unsolicited expressions.

Negative potential clues

1. **Taciturn, flat, or deflated behavior after the round**

Points away from: Engagement and emotional investment; would suggest the format failed to generate genuine stakes.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. Post-round behavior in both sessions was animated and conversational.

Strength: N/A.

2. **Direct criticism of the format itself**

Points away from: Overall appeal; structural design coherence.

Observed: Partially (P1, D1).

Evidence: The commendation system was criticised as “overwhelming” and difficult to use, particularly the size of the badge list (P1, D1). This was a targeted structural criticism rather than a wholesale rejection. The issue of commendation size was not directly addressed by a design change; it is to some extent intrinsic to the system. However, participants recognized that cognitive load would decrease with familiarity: as an Evaluator learns the commendation list over repeated use, the overhead diminishes naturally. Participants also noted that a practical workaround is available from the start—an Evaluator can simply observe what debaters do well in their speeches and work backwards to identify which commendation matches, rather than scanning the list prospectively. This makes the system more accessible at small scale than it first appears.

Mechanic: The commendation list in the first design iteration (Annex A) was designed for tournament scale, where Evaluators memorize a limited set of commendations over repeated use; at small informal scale with an unfamiliar system, the cognitive overhead of tracking all options exceeded what the context could support. The issue is thus primarily one of onboarding rather than structural incoherence.

Strength: Moderate. Specific and actionable; confined to one subsystem; not generalized to the format overall; partially mitigated by intrinsic learning curve and retrospective matching strategy.

3. **Visible loss of focus or disengagement during speeches**

Points away from: Sustained attention; flow state during play.

Observed: Partially (P1).

Evidence: One participant appeared uncertain about what to do during the Subject role in the first playtest, producing visibly hesitant behavior. This was role-confusion-driven rather than disengagement with the format broadly, and was not repeated in the second playtest.

Mechanic: The S0 and S1 instructions in the first design iteration did not specify the Subject’s active task during other teams’ speeches, leaving the Subject without a clear role during the middle of the debate.

Strength: Weak. Single instance; role-specific; addressed in next design iteration.

4. **Expressed preference for returning to standard competitive debate**

Points away from: Standalone appeal; would suggest format is only tolerable as an alternative, not as a preferred experience.

Observed: Partially (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Across both playtests, a total of three participants—one in the first session and two in the second—expressed reservations tied to the format’s non-competitive

structure. All three were men who had been highly competitive and quite successful in traditional debate. In the first session, one participant described the format as “anticlimactic” and expressed missing the “ego-boosting” feeling of decisive victory (P1, D1); several others in that session suggested the format might be “easier” or “for beginners,” raising concern it could be perceived as less serious by the broader debate community. In the second session, in addition to similar sentiments, one participant raised a more structural concern: that the format’s apparent benefits might be partly an artifact of playing without an established meta—that as a meta develops around Inside Out (as it has in World Schools and BP), the same competitive pressures and strategic distortions that the format tries to eliminate could re-emerge. This is a theoretically significant observation worth tracking in future iterations.

Mechanic: The removal of binary win/loss outcomes and zero-sum scoring is a deliberate design choice; these negative responses confirm that mechanic is operating as designed, not malfunctioning. The format is not intended to serve this participant profile as a primary audience—though the meta-concern raised in D2 is a genuine design question about long-term robustness.

Strength: Moderate for scoping the target audience; weak as evidence of a format-wide problem. The meta-concern is Weak at this stage—speculative, without empirical basis—but theoretically interesting.

5. “Cringe” reactions to ritual elements or format conventions

Points away from: Immersive design; willingness to engage with the format’s fictional premise.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: The ending ritual (Rolling Out) was described by participants as “very robotic” and as something that “takes you out of the immersion” (P1, D1). This reaction recurred in the second playtest: participants were observed mumbling the scripted phrases rather than delivering them with investment, and the researcher (as designer) was asked by participants to justify the purpose of the ritual phrases—an indication of a breakdown in the fictional frame (P2, D2). This is the strongest negative engagement clue from either playtest. It indicates that immersion *was* present before that point—participants could be “in the story”—but was disrupted by the ritual structure. The ritual was redesigned in the third design iteration (Annex H); the revised version has not yet been tested.

Mechanic: The first-iteration Rolling Out ritual required all participants to recite identical scripted phrases (“Thank you for listening to me,” “Thank you for speaking your truth”), producing a collective recitation effect—uniform, simultaneous, formulaic—incompatible with the personal and emergent character of the rest of the format.

Strength: Strong. Multi-session; multi-report; behavioral disruption (mumbling, questioning designer); design response drafted but untested.

Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

Positive potential clues

1. Visibly high engagement and effort during speeches

Points toward: Cognitive challenge retained; participants investing effort proportional to competitive formats.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, T2).

Evidence: In the second playtest, all Value Defenders immediately adopted elaborate roleplay stances—second-person address, emotional tone, worldbuilding detail—suggesting high rhetorical investment (P2, T2). The first playtest also showed high investment: participants came up with elaborate and nuanced solutions, constructed careful arguments, and several delivered quite passionate speeches—fully “try-hard” play despite the unfamiliar format (P1).

Mechanic: The format as a whole. Interaction mechanics in particular—the Huddle and Points of Information—were among the most liked and requested features across both playtests, suggesting they play an especially important role in sustaining engagement and effort.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral.

2. Strong performance quality—complex arguments, empathetic reasoning, strategic engagement

Points toward: Format generating the right kind of cognitive demand.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Participants described “architecting solutions” as “very complex and interesting strategically” (P1, D1). In the second playtest, participants navigated value hierarchies and inter-value tensions without prompting. The Subject’s S0 and S2 speeches in the second playtest demonstrated sophisticated contextual reasoning (T2). Both sessions also produced strikingly high levels of acting and roleplay: players adopted character mannerisms, delivered emotionally engaged speeches, and one played a background soundtrack during their S1. A key question raised in debrief was whether this emotional register came at the expense of critical thinking—but the evidence suggests it did not: very elaborate solutions, practicalities-based argumentation, and careful value hierarchies were consistently present, indicating that critical thinking and emotional engagement coexisted rather than traded off (P1, P2, T2).

Mechanic: The motion structure provides a specific character context that makes empathetic reasoning contextually available and strategically useful, rewarding perspective-taking as a competitive skill. Notably, the source of performance pressure shifts in this format: rather than the win/loss dynamic, the pressure becomes social—being recognized and appreciated by fellow Inner Voices and the Subject for the quality and resonance of one’s contributions. This social pressure is intrinsically tied to the quality of the engagement rather than to a binary outcome, making it a more nuanced and arguably healthier motivator.

Strength: Moderate. Partially self-report; partially observed; consistent across sessions.

3. Extensive post-debate reflection without researcher prompting

Points toward: Format generating cognitive and emotional residue worth processing.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Both debrief sessions extended well beyond structured questions. Participants in the first playtest returned to discussing the motion’s dilemma long after the formal debrief. Participants in both sessions also discussed—with evident pride—how fun and interesting it had been to try out techniques that were new to them: the second-person address, the emotional appeals, the worldbuilding. This is a distinct form of reflection from dilemma-processing: it is reflection on craft and creative agency, suggesting the format activates not just cognitive and moral residue but performative pride in artistic experimentation.

Mechanic: The whole format; in particular, the open-ended character of the roleplay task provides room for genuine creative experimentation that standard debate’s tight genre conventions do not.

Strength: Moderate. Observed; informally behavioral; consistent across both playtests.

4. **Expressed drive to improve; participants identifying their own growth edges**

Points toward: Format creating the kind of productive pressure that motivates development.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Participants in the first session said they would aim to be “more emotionally immersed” on replay (P1, D1), identifying immersion as a dimension they had not yet mastered. In the second playtest, participants initiated a group conversation about a specific skill the format demands but they found difficult: being polite when doing counter-argumentation—navigating how to diminish the relevance of another Inner Voice’s points without it feeling dismissive or adversarial (P2, D2). This reflects a more specific and format-native growth edge than emotional immersion, and was entirely self-identified. However, the very informal friends-hangout setting of the second session made the learning conversation less sustained and dynamic than it might have been in a more structured context; the topic was raised but not fully explored.

Mechanic: The commendation system names specific skills (e.g., “Believable Passion”) that participants can identify as aspirational targets; the roleplay dimension of the format provides a specific, named axis for development on replay that is recognized as distinct from standard debate skills. The polite counter-argumentation skill is format-specific: standard debate does not reward it, so recognizing it as a growth edge requires playing Inside Out.

Strength: Moderate. Self-report; forward-looking; actual improvement behavior untested. The P2 polite counter-argumentation conversation is particularly interesting as a format-native, self-generated growth goal.

Negative potential clues

1. **Apathy or minimal effort during speeches**

Points away from: Format generating meaningful productive pressure.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. All participants engaged substan-

tively with their speeches.

Strength: N/A.

2. Improvement discussion only when directly prompted by evaluator or researcher

Points away from: Intrinsic motivation to grow; would suggest format is experienced as externally evaluated rather than self-developing.

Observed: Partially (D1, D2).

Evidence: Some debrief forms contained brief or minimal self-improvement reflections that appeared to be prompted rather than unprompted. However, other responses in both sessions were substantive and self-initiated. The pattern is inconclusive.

Strength: Weak. Inconclusive; mixed within both debrief sets.

3. Confusion about what to do within role; confusion about how to improve

Points away from: Immediate accessibility; clear pressure architecture.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2).

Evidence: In the first playtest, the Subject player described not knowing “what to say” or how to “play very clean,” uncertain how to hold both emotional investment and evaluative neutrality simultaneously (P1, D1). In the second playtest, the Subject ran out of prepared Huddle questions before the 10 minutes elapsed (P2), revealing that the role requires more scaffolding than the ruleset provided. Both gaps were addressed in the second design iteration.

Mechanic: The S0 speech instructions in the first iteration did not specify the Subject’s emotional register or clarify the relationship between roleplay inhabitation (appropriate in S0/S1) and evaluative synthesis (appropriate in S2); the Huddle preparation time did not scaffold the kinds of questions the Subject should prepare. Both gaps were directly addressed in the second design iteration’s revised Subject role instructions.

Strength: Strong as a design-gap indicator. Behavioral; multi-instance; directly theoretically informative.

Field 3: Growth Direction—Useful Skills and Perspectives

Positive potential clues

1. Novel play patterns transferring real-world skills (empathy, contextual reasoning, negotiation)

Points toward: Format’s procedural rhetoric successfully encoding and transmitting its intended skill set.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2, T2).

Evidence: In the second playtest, all Value Defenders spontaneously adopted second-person address, direct eye contact with the Subject, and contextualizing worldbuilding details—none of which were instructed in the ruleset (P2, T2). In the first playtest, participants articulated learning to “think about the context of decisions” and to be

“more human and more honest about human nature” (P1, D1). One participant noted the format develops “conversational skills and empathy without necessarily having this educational background” (P2, D2). Three additional novel play patterns are worth noting: (1) a consistently *polite and collaborative form of counter-argumentation* emerged organically—players shifted focus rather than attacked, built on others rather than dismantling them, and recognized that outright rebuttal felt “wrong” in this context; (2) participants in the second playtest spontaneously moved toward *alignment on a common solution* across the second round of speeches, a behavior directly inverse to standard debate and a paradigmatic instance of the format’s procedural rhetoric encoding collaborative negotiation; (3) a *push toward synthesis* was evident in both rounds, with players building on rather than contradicting prior contributions—mirroring the kind of constructive dialogue the format is designed to develop.

Mechanic: The character assignment system (“you represent the Subject’s value of X”) and the personal dilemma motion structure (providing a named character with specific circumstances) invite perspective-taking without instructing it; the Subject as a named individual rather than an abstract adjudicator provides a concrete human recipient for empathetic reasoning. The absence of a rebuttal-rewarding scoring category inverts the rhetorical incentive structure, making polite, collaborative, synthesis-oriented engagement strategically advantageous rather than weakly punished.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral for second playtest; self-report for first playtest; consistent direction.

2. Continuation of standard debate’s positive skill patterns (research, structured argumentation)

Points toward: Format building on rather than displacing existing debate skills.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2).

Evidence: Participants continued to employ structured argument construction and research-based reasoning within speeches. The format did not produce a drift toward purely emotional or anecdotal argument; the value-argumentation task retained intellectual rigor.

Mechanic: The speech order (A1, B1, C1, S1, A2, B2, C2, S2) preserves the argument-sequencing logic of standard debate; the value-argumentation task still rewards research and logical structure, redirected toward value priority rather than policy consequence chains.

Strength: Low. Observational; consistent across both playtests, but it may be due more to the profile of the participants as experienced debaters.

3. Good play (empathetic, collaborative, value-aware) visibly rewarded in Subject Speech, Oral Critique, and debrief

Points toward: Evaluative culture aligned with transformative design intent.

Observed: Partially (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Evaluators acknowledged empathetic and value-aware play in both oral critiques. Both playtest oral critiques were very insightful and offered meaningful feedback that rewarded good play. However, in both playtests Subject decisions did more rather reward overly-analytical play, but that points more towards the profile of the

participants as highly experienced debaters.

Mechanic: The oral critique provides a structured feedback channel explicitly tied to the evaluator’s observations; the commendation system names specific skills to reward. Both mechanisms are directionally correct but depend on evaluator familiarity with the system, which is immature at small scale.

Strength: Moderate. Partially implemented; evaluative culture immature at small scale.

Negative potential clues

1. Non-standard behaviors being rewarded that do not transfer real-world skills

Points away from: Skill development value; would suggest format incentivizes play that is idiosyncratic to Inside Out rather than transferable.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. No evaluator praise for behaviors inconsistent with empathy, contextual reasoning, or collaborative discourse was recorded.

Strength: N/A.

2. Emergence of unhelpful new play patterns (e.g., hollow performative emotionality without substance)

Points away from: Skill transfer; would suggest format’s emotional register invites performance rather than genuine reflection.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. Emotional engagement observed in both sessions was substantively connected to argument construction and scenario reasoning.

Strength: N/A.

3. Immersion-breaking format elements preventing the bleed arc from completing

Points away from: Memetic and emancipatory bleed; a truncated immersion arc limits transformative potential.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1).

Evidence: The ending ritual (Rolling Out) was experienced as “very robotic” and described as breaking immersion at the moment it was intended to complete the emotional arc (P1, D1). Because emancipatory bleed requires a sustained transformational container through closing, a ritual that breaks character at the end undermines the mechanism. This is the most significant growth-direction design gap identified.

Mechanic: The first-iteration Rolling Out ritual required participants to recite identical scripted phrases in sequence, producing a uniform collective-recitation effect incompatible with the personal and emergent character of preceding play. The ritual was redesigned in the third design iteration (Annex H); that revised version has not yet been tested.

Strength: Strong. Multi-report; behavioral disruption; theoretical mechanism clearly implicated; design response drafted but untested.

Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

Positive potential clues

1. Unsolicited expressions of safety and reduced anxiety

Points toward: Transformational container functioning; psychological safety achieved without sacrificing engagement.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: “Much much less anxiety-inducing than standard debate” was consistently reported across both playtests and multiple independent participants (P1, P2, D1, D2). Participants described the experience as “quieter, more rested” (P1) and noted a “feeling of salvation regardless of the result” (P2, D2). The consistency across two independent groups strengthens confidence in this finding.

Mechanic: Four mechanics operate jointly to reduce performance anxiety: (1) the Evaluator seating arrangement places the observer out-of-sight and peripheral, removing the primary anxiety-generating figure of standard debate; (2) no public scoring occurs during the round; (3) binary win/loss outcomes are removed, eliminating zero-sum social capital stakes; (4) the personal dilemma motion has no objectively correct answer, removing the possibility of being demonstrably wrong.

Strength: Very strong. Multiple independent reports; consistent across two sessions; theoretically predicted prerequisite for bleed.

2. Brave, vulnerable play acknowledged and rewarded

Points toward: Evaluative culture recognizing and incentivizing the emotional risk the format asks of participants.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Multiple instances of brave and unconventional play were observed across both playtests. In the first session, the C team chose a deliberately vulnerable and conversational approach—emotionally intimate and unhurried—that is highly uncommon in the standard formats those participants were trained in; this was noted by others and acknowledged in the oral critique (P1, D1). In the second session, brave play took several forms: the S1 player chose to play a background soundtrack during their opening speech, a choice with no precedent in debate and a real social risk; the C team built their entire case around a worldbuilt character (the Subject’s mother) and her emotional stakes; players across the room adopted highly expressive, roleplay-heavy delivery styles; and participants responded to these choices with visible gesture-based approval and enthusiastic nonverbal acknowledgment throughout—laughing, nodding, leaning forward. The unplanned bleed event—a participant sharing privately that the scenario hit close to a real family situation—was also noted and acknowledged in the oral critique (P2, D2). Formal commendation assignment for brave play was not consistently enacted due to system immaturity.

Mechanic: The bleed-check moment in the third-iteration Rolling Out ritual explicitly creates a designated space for emotional acknowledgment; the Evaluator role instructions frame psychological safety as a primary responsibility, making responsive acknowledgment of vulnerable play structurally expected. The removal of win/loss outcomes reduces the cost of unconventional choices, making brave play a lower-risk

option.

Strength: Strong; multi-instance; behavioral; evaluative response was informal rather than systematic.

3. **Participants articulating liberation from standard debate’s performance pressure (emancipatory bleed)**

Points toward: Emancipatory bleed occurring: participants experiencing the format as freeing rather than constraining, and building confidence in their ability to speak up.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: “More relaxed, not performing execrably, felt like playing really okay” (P1, D1); “gives a little feeling of salvation, regardless of the result” (P2, D2); “everyone distinguished himself by his own style, which in ordinary debate competitions does not happen” (P2, D2). These reflections articulate a liberation from the evaluative regime of standard debate, congruent with previously reported clues of an overall much lower level of anxiety experienced by all participants.

Mechanic: Character assignment externalizes personal value expression into a role (“I am arguing for the value of X”), reducing the social exposure of holding a minority position; the removal of binary outcomes eliminates the competitive cost of expressing an unconventional view; the personal style encouraged by the roleplay premise means individual expressiveness is rewarded rather than penalized.

Strength: Strong. Consistent across both playtests; multiple independently-worded formulations of the same attitudinal shift.

4. **Emergent norms of collaborative rather than adversarial discourse**

Points toward: Format’s procedural rhetoric successfully reshaping community conduct without explicit instruction.

Observed: Yes (P2, D2).

Evidence: Participants in the second playtest spontaneously articulated that “outright attacking others’ points feels wrong, disrespectful, and unnecessary.” This was not a rule in the format but an emergent norm arising from the format’s structure—a paradigmatic instance of procedural rhetoric in action. Players also noted that shifting focus and building on others’ contributions felt “more natural and more persuasive” than traditional rebuttal.

Mechanic: The Subject as shared persuasion target means all Value Defenders are competing for the same person’s attention rather than defeating each other; no scoring category rewards rebuttal specifically, meaning attacking a competitor’s argument carries no direct competitive benefit while building on it does—this inverts the rhetorical incentive structure of standard competitive debate.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral; emergent; unsolicited; theoretically predicted.

Negative potential clues

1. **Expressions of distress during or after the round**

Points away from: Psychological safety; would suggest the format activates personal stakes without providing sufficient containment.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. The unplanned bleed event (participant sharing a real family situation) was handled calmly within the debrief structure; no distress was recorded. The bleed-check and debrief protocols appear to have functioned as intended.

Strength: N/A. Notable absence given the emotional intensity of some moments.

2. Arrogant, dismissive, or unempathetic behavior during debate

Points away from: Community health; toxicity reduction.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. No dismissive or contemptuous behavior toward other participants was recorded in either field notes or transcripts.

Strength: N/A.

3. Such behavior being praised by the evaluator or community

Points away from: Evaluative culture aligned with design intent; would signal the format’s recognition system is rewarding the wrong behaviors.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest.

Strength: N/A.

Field 5: Epistemic Humility

Positive potential clues

1. Unprompted awareness that multiple competing perspectives hold genuine value

Points toward: Core attitudinal shift targeted by the format: epistemic humility arising from procedural engagement with value conflict.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: “Every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us” (P1, D1). This formulation—articulated without prompting after a single encounter—captures precisely the attitudinal shift the design targets: moving from “which side is right” to “what do I value and why.” Additional supporting evidence from the first playtest includes participants articulating that arguing someone is “morally wrong” for their personal decisions feels “a bit absurd” in this context, and recognition that the format makes personal value priorities legible rather than evaluating them against an external standard (P1, D1). In the second playtest, a notable extended conversation emerged in the debrief about how the Subject’s opening speech (S0) institutionalises the practice of surfacing personal biases—making explicit what a player personally cares about before the debate even begins. Participants contrasted this with other formats, where the pretense of objectivity is maintained throughout: in those formats, they argued, biases are falsely supposed not to exist, propagating the idea that only one particular type of “objective” person can judge well and legitimizing social pressure to perform that identity. The S0 mechanism, by contrast, invites players to name their values openly from the start, reframing bias not as contamination

but as perspective (P2, D2).

Mechanic: The three-value motion structure assigns each team a value that is genuinely defensible for the character; the Subject’s final synthesis requirement frames the question as “what matters most to this person in this context” rather than “which position is objectively correct,” making all three perspectives legitimate from the outset. The S0 speech institutionalises bias transparency rather than suppressing it, which makes epistemic humility structurally available rather than personally effortful.

Strength: Moderate. Multi-session; self-report; directly on-target with design intent; P1 formulation notable for being unprompted; P2 debrief conversation particularly theoretically rich.

2. **Demonstrated understanding that personal values are context-dependent, not universal**

Points toward: Internalization of the format’s procedural rhetoric: that decisions are contextually embedded and legitimately vary by person and circumstance.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, T2).

Evidence: “Sometimes decisions are personal, not universal” (P1, D1). The Subject’s S0 and S2 arc in the second playtest demonstrated a similar trajectory: moving from roleplay inhabitation (personal, contextual) toward evaluative synthesis (what values do I hold about this?), with explicit self-awareness of that transition (P2, T2).

Mechanic: The character-specific motion context (personal history, relationships, circumstances) makes universal moral claims strategically inappropriate to the scenario; the S0 instructions ask the Subject to describe the scenario from a personal perspective before argumentation begins, embedding contextual reasoning before any abstract principle is introduced.

Strength: Moderate. Multi-session; self-report and behavioral; theoretical coherence strong.

3. **Spontaneous movement toward synthesis rather than competitive winning**

Points toward: Format orienting participants toward value integration rather than dominance—the deepest available behavioral indicator of epistemic humility in action.

Observed: Yes (P2, T2).

Evidence: In the second round and also less in the first one of Value Defender speeches, participants naturally moved toward synthesis rather than intensifying conflict—the reverse of what standard debate produces. This was not instructed; it emerged from the format’s procedural logic (P2, T2). Additionally, the Subject’s opening statement “I’m not sure if that’s the solution—that’s why this thing is eating at me” (P2, T2, transcript-confirmed) demonstrates genuine epistemic uncertainty from the start of the round, produced by the format’s demand that the Subject hold the dilemma rather than resolve it prematurely. Two further details reinforce this orientation toward collegiality and synthesis: (1) participants in the second playtest organically renamed themselves “Inner Voices” (which was subsequently formalized in the third design iteration), a label that positions them as parts of a shared internal deliberation rather than as opposing sides—colleagues rather than opponents; (2) the rules themselves permit multiple Inner Voices to argue for the same solution, structurally allowing con-

sensus rather than requiring disagreement, which removes the adversarial constraint that standard debate formats impose.

Mechanic: Speeches A2/B2/C2 are expected to build on A1/B1/C1 rather than dismantle competitors' positions. The Subject's S1 is an explicitly preliminary decision requiring ongoing engagement, structurally rewarding continued dialogue. The Huddle allows the Subject to ask clarifying questions, modeling collaborative inquiry as a legitimate competitive move. The Inner Voices naming and the same-solution permission together reframe competition from adversarial to collegial at the level of both identity and rules.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral; transcript-confirmed; emergent; theoretically predicted.

Negative potential clues

1. Unequivocal condemnation of beliefs or belief-holders

Points away from: Epistemic humility; would indicate the format is activating moral certainty rather than productive uncertainty.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest or in the transcripts. No unequivocal condemnation of a position, values system, or person was recorded.

Strength: N/A. Absence is notable given that the motions used both involved choices with genuine ethical weight.

2. Such condemnation being normalized or praised

Points away from: Community epistemic culture; would signal the format's evaluative frame rewards dogmatic certainty.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest.

Strength: N/A.